

RESEARCH ARTICLE

Phreaking Politics in Modern America

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Abstract

In the 1970s, activists in the Youth International Party transformed new technologies and techniques in the American telephone system into tools for advancing the political aims of the New Left. The Yippies adopted new practices of telephone “hacking” or “phone phreaking” and developed these practices to manipulate, defraud, and protest the AT&T Bell System. Appeals to and protests of “the system” invoked the image of a broader American state. The practice of phone phreaking bridged the technical exploitation of AT&T with critiques of monopoly capitalism, state surveillance, postwar conformity, and American empire. By the late 1970s, as the New Left faded in prominence and the Bell System was itself broken up, the vernacular of system changed. Within an emerging “computer underground” of phreaks, hackers, and users connected through electronic bulletin board systems, the Yippie vernacular of system was reinterpreted as a critique of the state in the language of ascendant conservative and libertarian politics.

In the early 1970s, journalists, policymakers, and corporate executives in the United States grew concerned with a growing group of college students, telephone tinkerers, and electronics hobbyists who dubbed themselves “phone phreaks.” The phreaks, whose name reflected a phonetic play on “phone” and “freak,” were “college students high on electronic circuitry, freckle-faced teen-agers,” “pranksters,” and “blind kids,” wrote *Los Angeles Times* columnist Maureen Orth. They knew telephones “the way Ralph Nader knows General Motors.”¹

Phreaking, as its practitioners described it, was the practice of manipulating and experimenting with the American telephone system. The icon of American telephony was AT&T, or the “Bell System,” a public monopoly and America’s dominant telephone service provider. To the phreak, Bell was an “electronic playground.”² It was a “huge game and Ma Bell was ‘it,’” as one Bell security agent described the phreaks who bedeviled him.³ A phreak’s principal tool was the “Blue Box,” a multifrequency device that allowed its users to call anyone, anywhere, anytime—for free. As Ron Rosenbaum wrote in “Secrets of the Little Blue Box,” an October 1972 *Esquire* feature, “it gives you the power of a super operator.”⁴ By the mid-1970s, front-page features in the *Wall Street Journal* suggested that tens of thousands of Americans, from college students to businessmen, celebrities, and white-collar criminals, dabbled in

¹Maureen Orth, “For Whom Ma Bell Tolls Not,” *Los Angeles Times*, Oct. 31, 1971, 28.

²Phil Lapsley, “Birth of a Playground,” in *Exploding the Phone: The Untold Story of the Teenagers and Outlaws Who Hacked Ma Bell* (New York, 2013), 14–28.

³Quote from a Pacific Bell senior security agent, Howard Mountjoy, in Evan Maxwell, “Phone Crooks Play Game With Blue Box,” *Los Angeles Times*, Aug. 26, 1973, OC2.

⁴Ron Rosenbaum, “Secrets of the Little Blue Box,” *Esquire*, Oct. 1971, 117.

phreaking.⁵ What compelled such a wide berth of Americans to wrangle their way through the Bell System?

As phreaking gained notoriety, observers in the press pointed to parallels between phone phreaking and the broader countercultural movements of the 1960s and 1970s. As one *Washington Post* columnist noted in 1971, “sophisticated chiselers with pocket-sized electronic ‘blue boxes’” were not so much curious college students or harmless hobbyists as activists and punks inspired by the New Left, especially the provocateur Abbie Hoffman.⁶ In the *New York Times*, columnist Michael Drosnin concurred by casting phone phreaking as an outgrowth of Hoffman’s “radical ideology” of “theft-without-guilt,” an ideology that understood “America as a society based on the rip-off.”⁷

Ripping off the telephone company was a recurring theme in Hoffman’s writing and speaking in the early 1970s. In *Steal This Book*, Hoffman’s 1971 bestselling outline for waging “Monkey Warfare” against American government and corporations, Hoffman wrote that “as long as there is a phone company, and as long as there are outlaws, nobody need ever pay for a call.”⁸ More importantly, though, Hoffman argued that phreaking was an activist act; with practice, a phreak’s tools could become the implements of dissatisfied Americans seeking political change. Thus, when Hoffman acquired a copy of Rosenbaum’s 1972 essay on the Blue Box, he studiously underlined many sentences and scribbled “Dig it!” at many points in the margins. But no annotation was more telling than his declaration atop the cover page: “WE MUST HAVE THIS DEVICE IN OUR REVOLUTIONARY ARESENAL.”⁹ (Figure 1) Hoffman, in short, saw phreaking as a radically new tool to revolutionize and democratize technology in modern America.

Critiques of AT&T resonated across American life in the 1960s and 70s. Indeed, Hoffman was hardly alone: the 1970s saw signs, t-shirts, leaflets, magazines, and buttons emblazoned with the phrase “Ma Bell is a Cheap Mother!” and more to the point, “Fuck the Bell System!”¹⁰ AT&T’s unsurpassed size and influence as the country’s largest public monopoly, its longstanding ties to military-industrial institutions and law enforcement, its discrimination against women and minorities, and the oppressive conformity within its intellectual and cultural climate—together, these elements made the Bell System a principal part of the American system writ large. Domestic political actors mounted sustained demonstrations against the Vietnam War, staged labor action against race and gender discrimination, and sounded alarms about creeping practices of technological surveillance. AT&T was a plausible adversary for those seeking change in each of these domains—and an easy object for the ire of those who simply sought to rage.¹¹ To its critics on the New Left, like Hoffman, AT&T’s telephone lines were reinterpreted as the wires of American empire.¹² Even in mainstream American society, where

⁵See, for example, Sanford L. Jacobs, “Blue Boxes Spread from Phone Freaks to the Well-Heeled,” *Wall Street Journal*, Jan. 29, 1976, 1.

⁶William L. Claiborne, “The Phone Phreak Crackdown,” *Washington Post*, Oct. 2, 1971, B2.

⁷Michael Drosnin, “Ripping Off, the New Life Style,” *The New York Times* Aug. 8, 1971, SM12. On Hoffman, see Jonah Raskin, *For the Hell of It: The Life and Times of Abbie Hoffman* (Berkeley, 1996).

⁸Hoffman’s manifesto sold over 250,000 copies in the spring of 1971 and was widely circulated, especially on college campuses. Abbie Hoffman, *Steal This Book* (New York, 1971).

⁹Ron Rosenbaum, “Secrets of the Little Blue Box,” *Esquire*, Oct. 1971, in “Legal Dope,” box 2019-050/14, Abbie Hoffman Papers, Dolph Briscoe Center for American History, Austin, Texas [Hereafter AHP].

¹⁰Terry H. Anderson, *The Movement and the Sixties: Protest in America from Greensboro to Wounded Knee* (New York, 1995), 362; Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*.

¹¹On the 1960s and 70s generally, see Kevin Boyle, *The Shattering: America in the 1960s* (New York, 2021); Bruce Schulman, *The Seventies: The Great Shift in American Culture, Society, and Politics* (New York, 2002); Todd Gitlin, *The Sixties: Years of Hope, Days of Rage* (New York, 1993).

¹²This essay uses AT&T, Ma Bell, the Bell System, and Bell interchangeably.

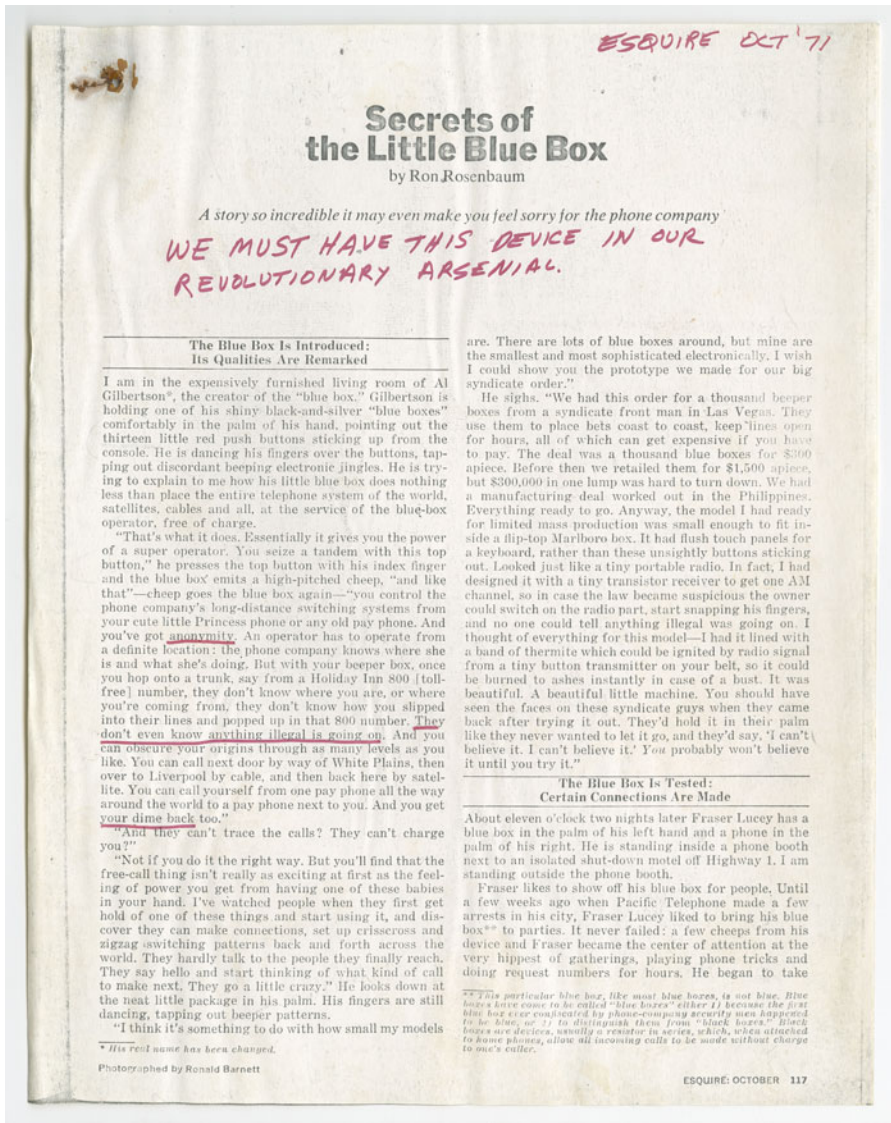


Figure 1. Abbie Hoffman's copy of Ron Rosenbaum's "Secrets of the Little Blue Box," a famous feature article in the October 1971 issue of *Esquire*.

Source: Ron Rosenbaum, "Secrets of the Little Blue Box," "Legal Dope," box 2019-050/14, Abbie Hoffman Papers. Photo: camh-dob-035240_0001, Dolph Briscoe Center for American History, Austin, Texas.

AT&T stood as a traditional symbol of the country's innovation, businessmen and lawmakers increasingly saw AT&T as a paradigmatic monopoly and prime target for antitrust law.¹³

These critiques of the Bell System, and the broader political economic systems it represented, were sketched in the *Youth International Party Line* (YIPL), a magazine Hoffman co-founded to bridge phone phreaking with New Left political preoccupations and repackage them in the

¹³ Antitrust is a recurring feature of AT&T's history, but such efforts culminated in 1982 through 1984 with AT&T's divestiture and breakup. On the breakup of the Bell System, see Leslie Cauley, *End of the Line: The Rise and Fall of AT&T* (New York, 2005); and Peter Temin and Louis Galambos, *The Fall of the Bell System: A Study in Prices and Politics* (Cambridge, 1987). For a critical contemporary account, see Constantine Raymond Kraus and Alfred W. Duerig, *The Rape of Ma Bell: The Criminal Wrecking of the Best Telephone System in the World* (New York, 1988).

provocative language of the Youth International Party (YIP). In 1967, New Left activists Abbie and Anita Hoffman, Jerry Rubin, Nancy Kurshan, and Paul Krassner created YIP as a new, experimental organization for coordinating protests. YIP joined other organizations on the New Left in embracing the promise of “participatory democracy” and creating decentralized and cooperative social, cultural, and economic institutions as foils to those in the mainstream.¹⁴

This article examines how activists and phone phreaks turned *YIPL* into an organ for sharing information about the Bell System. Its pages constituted a collective paper workbench advancing the “alternative” technology of phreaking and articulating its uses as a political tool to fight “the system.”¹⁵ As such, *YIPL*’s pages offer a glimpse into the processes of “mutual shaping” by which politicians, businessmen, journalists, social movements, and communities of telephone users determined the social significance of the telephone system and debated the politics of emerging technologies in modern America.¹⁶

Like other watchwords of the era, “system” had many meanings in modern America. Some were inflected by novel advances in science and technology, emerging social movements, and short-run political developments, while others reflected longstanding currents in American political culture or recurring features of the ideological struggles that characterized the Cold War. System could easily become a floating signifier, attaching to any structure or object of opposition: capitalism, American foreign policy, law enforcement, sexual norms. Which is to say, the more people talked about systems, the less they seemed to agree about what “systems” meant.¹⁷ Despite its diffuse uses, however, Yippies and phreaks offered a unique articulation of “system” amid this period’s profusion of metaphors—among them “the man,” “the machine,” and “Big Brother.” For the phreaks, invoking this metaphor rendered the Bell System into a powerful metonym for the broader American political economic order.¹⁸

But the community-oriented, anti-war, and countercultural politics of phreaking in the early 1970s morphed into an anarchistic and techno-libertarian politics by the late 1980s. Such a transformation from New Left to libertarian is a familiar story for American historians. As Fred Turner shows, the “New Communalism” created by techno-enthusiast hippies contained the seeds of a market-friendly politics, which ascended as “neoliberalism” as the tenets of a once-radical “counterculture” became the foundation for a libertarian “cyberculture.”¹⁹

¹⁴On “participatory democracy” and the social movements of the period in general, see Francesca Polletta, *Freedom Is an Endless Meeting: Democracy in American Social Movements* (Chicago, 2002); James Miller, *Democracy Is in the Streets: From Port Huron to the Siege of Chicago* (New York, 1987); and Richard Flacks and Nelson Lichtenstein, eds., *The Port Huron Statement: Sources and Legacies of the New Left’s Founding Manifesto* (Philadelphia, 2015).

¹⁵*YIPL* quickly became a node in the expansive network of infoshops, newspapers, and zines connecting the New Left in print. On the New Left, see Van Gosse, “A Movement of Movements: The Definition and Periodization of the New Left,” in *A Companion to Post-1945 America*, eds., Roy Rosenzweig and Jean-Christophe Agnew (London, 2002); and Van Gosse, *Rethinking the New Left: An Interpretive History* (New York, 2005). On the New Left’s print culture, see, for example, Kristen Hogan, *The Feminist Bookstore Movement: Lesbian Antiracism and Feminist Accountability* (Durham, 2016); and Michael Doyle, *Radical Chapters: Pacifist Bookseller Roy Kepler and the Paperback Revolution* (Syracuse, 2012). On the functions of other institutions, see Joshua Clark Davis, *From Head Shops to Whole Foods: The Rise and Fall of Activist Entrepreneurs* (New York, 2020).

¹⁶For more on the concept of social construction, see Wiebe E. Bijker and Trevor J. Pinch, eds., *Shaping Technology/Building Societies: Studies in Socio-Technical Change* (Cambridge, MA, 1994); and Donald A. MacKenzie and Judy Wajcman, *The Social Shaping of Technology: How the Refrigerator Got Its Hum* (Philadelphia, 1999).

¹⁷Here I paraphrase an anecdote from Ronald R. Kline in *The Cybernetics Moment: Or Why We Call Our Age the Information Age* (Baltimore, 2015), 7. On the proliferation of “system” in this period’s social scientific thought, see Hunter Heyck, *Age of System: Understanding the Development of Modern Social Science* (Baltimore, 2015).

¹⁸Daniel Rodgers, *Age of Fracture* (Cambridge, MA, 2011), 10.

¹⁹Fred Turner, *From Counterculture to Cyberculture: Stewart Brand, the Whole Earth Network, and the Rise of Digital Utopianism* (Chicago, 2006). Also see Thomas Frank’s conceptualization of “hip consumerism” in *The Conquest of Cool: Business Culture, Counterculture, and the Rise of Hip Consumerism* (Chicago, 2006). On the

Period portrayals of “the revolution [as] not something to be fought for, but something to be relaxed into, lived and experienced in the moment,” transformed the processes of self-making and remaking into the principal terrain of political activity.²⁰ According to Gary Gerstle, challenges to midcentury “political order” from the New Left prized the self as the site of political change, valorized the individual, and, ironically, became a vector for “neoliberal” ideas in the United States and abroad.²¹ The New Left-to-libertarian or neoliberal arc comports with the critical posture of academics and politicians vexed by the New Left, then and now, who waved away the Yippies as nothing more than “cultural leftists” who eschewed politics and, above all, as Hoffman himself opined in 1968, chased “risk, drama, excitement, and bullshit.”²²

In following phone phreaking’s trajectory from a tool claimed by New Left communities in communitarian, anti-war, and labor struggles of the 1970s, to an increasingly libertarian politics in the 1980s, historians can view the origins of American techno-libertarian politics in a new light.²³ More than a catalog of one political vision’s decline, or the revelation that one political movement contained the seeds of another, this history points to enduring continuities between the Yippies-turned-phreaks of the 1970s and the hacker cultures of the 1980s and 1990s.²⁴

By examining phreaking in the political context of AT&T’s political and infrastructural omnipresence in twentieth-century America, we bridge the interests of historians who map “political orders” and “socio-technical regimes” with the concerns of scholars invested in reassembling the cultures and practices of groups like the phreaks.²⁵ Writing on Silicon Valley is exemplary of this synthesis, but readers of recent historiography may well wonder how the tension between politics and technology manifests in the vast geography of modern America,

broader relationship between the New Left and New Right, see Rebecca E. Klatch, *A Generation Divided: The New Left, the New Right, and the 1960s* (Berkeley, 1999).

²⁰Sam Binkley, *Getting Loose: Lifestyle Consumption in the 1970s* (Durham, 2007), 17.

²¹Gary Gerstle, *The Rise and Fall of the Neoliberal Order: America and the World in the Free Market Era* (Oxford, 2022).

²²Maurice Isserman and Michael Kazin, *America Divided: The Civil War of the 1960s* (Oxford, 2000), 161, 233; Raskin, *For the Hell of It*, 129. In a prelude to the arguments of Turner, Gerstle, and others, Isserman and Kazin described the “New Radicalism” of the 1960s as the product of midcentury America’s middle-class domesticity, a “nursery” that had reared students to search for “authenticity” in the revolts of the 1960s, rather than formal political change. See Maurice Isserman and Michael Kazin, “The Failure and Success of the New Radicalism,” in *The Rise and Fall of the New Deal Order, 1930-1980*, eds. Gary Gerstle and Steve Fraser (Princeton, 1989), 212-42.

²³As Whitney McIntosh writes, the scholarship on libertarianism remains partisan and diffuse. For introductions to its place in the historiography, see McIntosh, “Libertarianism: An Emergent Field,” *Reviews in American History* 52, no. 4 (2024): 359-69; Brian Doherty, *Radicals for Capitalism: A Freewheeling History of the Modern American Libertarian Movement* (New York, 2008); Jennifer Burns, “O Libertarian, Where Is Thy Sting?,” *Journal of Policy History* 19, no. 4 (Oct. 2007): 452-70; and John L. Kelley, *Bringing the Market Back in: The Political Revitalization of Market Liberalism* (New York, 1997). On more critical genealogies of techno-libertarianism or “cyberlibertarianism,” see David Golumbia, *Cyberlibertarianism: The Right-Wing Politics of Digital Technology* (Minneapolis, 2024); and Finn Brunton, *Digital Cash: The Unknown History of the Anarchists, Utopians, and Technologists Who Created Cryptocurrency* (Princeton, 2019).

²⁴On phreaking’s influence in hacker culture broadly, see Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*; and Jacob A. Bruggeman, “Phreaking the U.K.,” *Interfaces: Essays and Reviews on Computing and Culture* Vol. 6 (Jan. 2025), Charles Babbage Institute, University of Minnesota, 1-8. Lapsley’s account of phreaking, the only book-length study to date, provides a brilliant narrative placing the phone phreaks in rich social and historical context, but examining the political meaning of phreaking as a technological practice is not Lapsley’s primary aim. Gabriela Coleman’s *Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy: The Many Faces of Anonymous* (London, 2014) goes further, tracing how phreaking informs the culture of hackers in the 2000s, especially their politics and malevolent humor, known as the “Lulz.”

²⁵On political orders, see Gerstle, *The Rise and Fall of the Neoliberal Order*; Gary Gerstle, Nelson Lichtenstein, and Alice O’Connor, eds., *Beyond the New Deal Order: U.S. Politics from the Great Depression to the Great Recession* (Philadelphia, 2019); Gerstle and Fraser, eds., *The Rise and Fall*. On sociotechnical regimes, see Gabrielle Hecht, *The Radiance of France: Nuclear Power and National Identity after World War II* (Cambridge, MA, 2009); and Sara B. Pritchard, *Confluence: The Nature of Technology and the Remaking of the Rhône* (Cambridge, MA, 2011).

well beyond the Bay Area.²⁶ The history of hacking, which academic and popular accounts often study in institutions like Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT), share some geographical and conceptual constraints.²⁷

Indeed, phreaks and hackers complicate the typical boundaries historians use to categorize states, corporations, science, and technologies, and thereby provide an opportunity to weave methods across these historical subfields.²⁸ Phreaks, users on the margins of American telephony, took to writing, protesting, and technological practice to express themselves and seek political change. Seeking to understand the ideas, practices, and relationships between communities of users gets beyond well-told stories about politicians, executives, and engineers, while revealing an unlikely case of innovators, maintainers, disruptors, and everyday people reconfiguring and cocreating the technologies that shape their lives.²⁹ The site of that analysis here is the infrastructure of the United States' telecommunications system, whose crossed wires were the sites for many of the most pressing political conflicts of the twentieth century.³⁰

That phone phreaks and hackers do not just merely argue about technology, but “also argue through it,” suggests that technical practice be taken seriously as a political activity.³¹ In forums like *YIPL*, phreaks and, eventually, hackers created “recursive publics” vitally invested in the material and technical evolution of technology and technological systems; the legal, ethical, and conceptual dimensions of technological development; and the relationships between social and political imaginaries and real possibilities—and, conversely, the structures technology reinforces and the futures it renders impossible.³² Phreaking, like practices of hacking, coding, patching, tinkering, and sharing, reconstituted the relationships between Americans and the broader technological systems they lived with and through.³³ Examining the political justifications for

²⁶On the political economy of Silicon Valley, see, for example, Margaret O'Mara, *Cities of Knowledge: Cold War Science and the Search for the Next Silicon Valley* (Princeton, 2005); Leslie Berlin, *The Man Behind the Microchip: Robert Noyce and the Invention of Silicon Valley* (Oxford, 2005); and AnnaLee Saxenian, *Regional Advantage: Culture and Competition in Silicon Valley and Route 128* (Cambridge, MA, 1996); on its cultures, see Turner, *From Counterculture to Cyberculture*, J.A. English-Lueck, *Cultures@SiliconValley* (Stanford, 2002); John Markoff, *What the Dormouse Said: How the Sixties Counterculture Shaped the Personal Computer Industry* (New York, 2005); and Alice E. Marwick, *Status Update: Celebrity, Publicity, and Branding in the Social Media Age* (New Haven, 2013); on culture and knowledge work, see Shalin Shankari, *Desi Land: Teen Culture, Class, and Success in Silicon Valley* (Durham, 2008); and Stephen R. Barley and Gideon Kunda, *Gurus, Hired Guns, and Warm Bodies: Itinerant Experts in a Knowledge Economy* (Princeton, 2006).

²⁷Blockbuster accounts from the 1980s and 1990s uncovered the evolution of hacking on campuses like MIT but also enshrined the university as the site of “true” hacking. See, for example, Steven Levy, *Hackers: Heroes of the Computer Revolution* (New York, 1984); and Sherry Turkle, *The Second Self: Computers and the Human Spirit* (Cambridge, MA, 2005).

²⁸On hackers on boundary work, see Walter Scheirer, *A History of Fake Things on the Internet* (Stanford, 2024); Héctor Beltrán, *Code Work: Hacking Across the US/México Techno-Borderlands* (Princeton, 2023); Luca Follis and Adam Fish, *Hacker States* (Cambridge, MA, 2020); and Coleman, *Coding Freedom: The Ethics and Aesthetics of Hacking* (Princeton, 2012).

²⁹On the turn to use, broadly, see Trevor J. Pinch and Wiebe E. Bijker, “The Social Construction of Facts and Artefacts: Or How the Sociology of Science and the Sociology of Technology Might Benefit Each Other,” in *The Social Construction of Technological Systems*, eds. Wiebe E. Bijker, Thomas P. Hughes, and Trevor Pinch (Cambridge, MA, 1993), 17–50.

³⁰The most significant effort in this camp of scholarship is Dan Schiller, *Crossed Wires: The Conflicted History of U.S. Telecommunications, from the Post Office to the Internet* (Oxford, 2023). In particular, see chapter nine, “The 1960s,” 388–450. For earlier works on the intersection of protest and telecommunications in modern America, see Dorothy Sue Cobble, *The Other Women's Movement: Workplace Justice and Social Rights in Modern America* (Princeton, 2004); and Venus Green, *Race on the Line: Gender, Labor, and Technology in the Bell System, 1880–1980* (Durham, 2001).

³¹Christopher Kelty, *Two Bits: The Cultural Significance of Free Software* (Durham, 2008), 44.

³²Kelty, *Two Bits*, 3.

³³Coleman, *Coding Freedom*; Kelty, *Two Bits*, 3, 6–7, 8.

phreaking as vernacular politics uncovers a Yippie-influenced point of origin for “hacker culture,” with all its pranking, dark humor, and ambivalent politics.³⁴ But the politics of phreaking were only temporarily settled in the early 1970s. Like the widespread invocation of “the system” itself, phreaking came to represent a variety of political views in modern America.

The Bell System

The Bell System emerged as the backbone of American telecommunications from the social, political, and technological shocks to American life in the late nineteenth century. Founded in 1875, the American Telegraph & Telephone Company (AT&T) entered a phase of aggressive expansion (or, as one historian thematized the company’s history in 1939, “industrial conquest”).³⁵ After a series of acquisitions in the 1880s, AT&T came to be. Led by the bullish AT&T president Theodore N. Vail, a master of corporate intrigue and political maneuvering, AT&T secured the status of a public monopoly in U.S. telephone service in 1913, a position it would hold until the early 1980s.³⁶

Come the mid-twentieth century, AT&T had become a symbol of the American corporation. By 1960, AT&T was the world’s largest corporation. It employed over 1 million people—a workforce containing 7,452 Smiths, 5,880 Johnsons, 3,934 Williamses, 3,600 Browns, and 3,547 Joneses—and was an employer surpassed only by the federal government. AT&T’s assets totaled over \$114 billion, more than General Motors, Ford, General Electric, Chrysler, and IBM combined. It made \$16 million a day and \$11,000 per minute. The Bell System owned a total of 24,000 buildings, from small brick facades on midwestern Main Streets to a brand-new, 2-million-square-foot headquarters for Southern Bell in Atlanta. It owned a fleet of 177,000 motor vehicles, including jeeps, scooters, and industrial trucks for material transportation. The AT&T long distance division even owned vessels to lay cable deep undersea.³⁷

If the cumulative size of its subdivisions testified to AT&T’s unparalleled capacity, the research and development within Bell Laboratories earned the company its reputation as the epicenter of technological innovation in the twentieth century. Therein, scientists, engineers, and technicians developed the transistor and early semiconductors, laying the foundation for modern computing. Amid the Cold War space race, they deployed the first communications satellite, the Telstar 1; and as cellular communications rose to prominence, they created some of the first cell phone networks. For many Americans, Bell Labs was the epitome of innovation. In the words of one journalist, it was the American century’s “idea factory.”³⁸ Western Electric, Bell’s manufacturing wing, was viewed in the same vein. To the public, Western Electric’s business was nothing short of “manufacturing the future.”³⁹

In the mid-twentieth century, the number of telephones in the United States grew dramatically. For example, in 1855, a decade after AT&T was created, there were 340,000 telephones in use across the United States. By 1965, this number had multiplied by a factor of

³⁴Coleman, *Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy*; Angela Nagel, *Kill All Normies: Online Culture Wars from 4chan to Tumblr to Trump and the Alt-Right* (Winchester, 2017).

³⁵N.R. Danielian, *A.T.&T.: The Story of Industrial Conquest* (New York, 1939).

³⁶On the telephone and AT&T generally, see Richard R. John, *Network Nation: Inventing American Telecommunications* (Cambridge, MA, 2010); Tim Wu, *The Master Switch: The Rise and Fall of Information Empires* (New York, 2010); Claude S. Fischer, *America Calling: A Social History of the Telephone to 1940* (Berkeley, 1992); and Sonny Kleinfield, *The Biggest Company on Earth: A Profile of AT&T* (New York, 1981). On Vail, see Richard R. John, “Theodore N. Vail and the civic origins of universal service,” *Business and Economic History* 28, no. 2 (Winter 1999): 71–81; Louis Galambos, “Theodore N. Vail and the Role of Innovation in the Modern Bell System,” *Business History Review* 66, no. 1 (Spring 1992): 95–126.

³⁷Kleinfield, *The Biggest Company on Earth*, 3, 4, 11, 12.

³⁸Jon Gertner, *The Idea Factory: Bell Labs and the Great Age of American Innovation* (New York, 2012).

³⁹Stephen B. Adams and Orville R. Butler, *Manufacturing the Future: A History of Western Electric* (Cambridge, 1999).

over 275 to 93,656,000—83% of which were Bell telephone models.⁴⁰ According to a 1969 report by McKinsey, the Bell System telephone network alone contained over a trillion components, ranging from colored phones to cable lines between major metropolitan areas.⁴¹

For the first half of the twentieth century, the telephone company was represented by the operators: thousands of employees, mostly women, who would answer and connect callers to whomever they were trying to reach. But as Americans spread out in the postwar period—moving for work, for school, or simply to hit the road—the volume of long-distance dialing traffic ballooned.⁴² Executives at AT&T and engineers at Bell Labs realized that it would simply be impossible for a network stitched together with human switches (operators who connected calls manually by switchboard) to meet Americans' growing demand to talk over the telephone. Automation, they decided, would chart the path to a more robust telephone network. With the introduction of automated switching machines that routed long-distance calls, and new multifrequency tones in telephone equipment, the Bell System's network became what engineer Phil Lapsley called a "mechanized brain," and for its time, the "largest machine in the world."⁴³

The innovative automation of Ma Bell's network was a massive success—so much so that Bell openly advertised the inner workings of its long-distance system. In *Popular Mechanics*, Bell published an advertisement likening long-distance automatic dialing to "playing a tune for a telephone number" on a "musical keyboard," with each "key" corresponding to specific digital tones.⁴⁴ Bell released educational materials like the film "Speeding Speech," which described the technical operations of the system at length, even recording the exact tone sequences for each key.⁴⁵ And its flagship scientific journal, the *Bell System Technical Journal*, published a nearly step-by-step guide to using the new digital frequencies to start and end long-distance telephone calls.⁴⁶ Ma Bell, a monopoly at the peak of its influence in American life, did not fear that its secrets would fuel competition. But the Bell System's open distribution of technical information made it into a testing ground and back alley for an odd assortment of college students, tinkerers, bookies, and countercultural radicals: the phone phreaks.

The Origins of Phreaking

Drawing on the information Bell made publicly available, hundreds of hobbyists and tinkerers developed several methods to access the telephone network. As their numbers grew and the practice of information sharing developed regular channels of communication between individuals, a community of phone phreaks was born. In the late 1960s and early 1970s, Joe Engressia, a blind student with perfect pitch at the University of South Florida, earned the name

⁴⁰United States Census Bureau, *Historical Statistics of the United States: Colonial Times to 1970*, vol II, ed. William Lerner (Washington, D.C., 1975), 783–4.

⁴¹McKinsey and Co., *A Study of Western Electric's Performance* (New York, 1969).

⁴²On operators and women's labor in telephony, see David Alan Grier, *When Computers Were Human* (Princeton, 2005); Jennifer S. Light, "When Computers Were Women," *Technology and Culture* 40, no. 3 (July 1999): 455–83; and Kenneth Lipartito, "When Women Were Switches: Technology, Work, and Gender in the Telephone Industry, 1890–1920," *The American Historical Review* 99, no. 4 (Oct. 1994): 1075–111.

⁴³Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*, 44, 46–7. On rotary dialing, see M.D. Fagen, ed., *A History of Engineering and Science in the Bell System: The Early Years, 1875–1925* (New York, 1975). On the switch to touch tone dialing, see A.E. Joel Jr., ed., *A History of Engineering and Science in the Bell System: Switching Technology, 1925–1975* (New York, 1982).

⁴⁴American Telephone and Telegraph Co., "Playing a Tune for a Telephone Number," *Popular Science* (Feb. 1950), 5.

⁴⁵American Telephone and Telegraph Co., "Speeding Speech," 1950, <https://archive.org/details/Speeding1950> (accessed Aug. 8, 2025).

⁴⁶A. Weaver, N.A. Newell, "In-Band Single-Frequency Signaling," *Bell System Technical Journal* 33, no. 6 (Nov. 1954): 1309–30; C. Breen and C.A. Dahlbom, "Signaling Systems for Control of Telephone Switching," *Bell System Technical Journal* 39, no. 6 (Nov. 1960): 1381–444.

“Whistler” after he discovered that he could whistle the exact 2600Hz tone into the telephone to make free calls.⁴⁷ Other phreaks, like Sid Bernay, discovered that a toy whistle in a Cap’n Crunch cereal box emitted the same 2,600Hz tone needed to access the new Bell System long-distance network.⁴⁸ Telephone users could make free calls by recording the “ping” of a pay coin slotted into a pay phone, playing the recording into the receiver, and deceiving operators.⁴⁹

Plastic toys, perfect pitch, and clever tricks could only take phone phreaks so far, however. While the Bell System installed automated long-distance dialing mechanisms in the early 1950s and 1960s, other phone phreaks were at work constructing devices to mimic and exploit the multifrequency tones used in Bell’s new touch-tone system. Of the multifrequency devices phone phreaks created, none was more powerful (or infamous) than the Blue Box. Blue Boxes were thirteen-pushbutton devices that connected their users to the long-distance network by emitting the tones necessary to access it. With the invention and distribution of transistors in the 1950s and 1960s, handheld, battery-powered, and cheap Blue Boxes became feasible and widespread.⁵⁰ Blue Boxes could be constructed with parts purchased at a local hardware store or refashioned from electronic pianos and doorbells. Anyone with a rudimentary understanding of electronics could build one.

Phone phreaking quickly became a technical pastime with social significance. The phone phreaks were one of the many communities of young (mostly white) men who identified as hobbyists and tinkerers after World War II.⁵¹ As droves of mass-market radios, gadgets, and computers entered the consumer market, local and national groups of students, hobbyists, and enthusiasts of amateur radio, microcomputing, and gaming, for example, made tinkering and improving technology into a shared purpose and proving ground for intellectual and masculine identities.⁵² Historians of such communities demonstrate the paradoxes of their peripheries: they purported to prize technical skill above all else, welcoming “geeks,” “nerds,” and demobilized American G.I.s alike in the process, while often reproducing gendered and racial prejudices that reflexively closed their ranks to many other Americans.⁵³

The phreak’s obsession with technical knowledge made demonstrations of skill into socially significant performances among peers. In the late 1960s at MIT and Harvard, for example, students gained access to the Department of Defense’s Automatic Voice Network (AUTOVON) lines and started calling Strategic Air Command bases. “Our interest wasn’t in making free calls but in fooling a system that wasn’t designed to be fooled,” one of the students reported. “It was a challenge,” he continued, one that “revealed some aspects of the system that the company had

⁴⁷Times Bureau, “USF ‘Whistler’ Stays In School,” *St. Petersburg Times*, Dec. 12, 1968, B-1.

⁴⁸The phreak John Draper, well known by his pseudonym, “Captain Crunch,” has long claimed that he discovered the Cap’n Crunch whistle as a phreak’s tool, but Bernay discovered this fact years earlier. See Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*, 154–5; on the myth of Captain Crunch, see John Draper and C. Wilson Fraser, *Beyond the Little Blue Box: The Biographical Adventures of John T. Draper* (Victoria, 2018).

⁴⁹“Fiddler on the line can’t be caught, yet,” *New Scientist*, Oct. 19, 1972, 148.

⁵⁰On the Blue Box, see *Exploding the Phone*; on the transistor and digital technologies in the 1950s and 1960s, see Chris Miller, *Chip War: The Fight for the World’s Most Critical Technology* (New York, 2022).

⁵¹While the historical record is not rich enough for a full reconstruction of phreak demographics, the textual evidence suggests most phreaks were male.

⁵²See Carly A. Kocurek, *Coin-Operated Americans: Rebooting Boyhood at the Video Game Arcade* (Minneapolis, 2015); Art M. Blake, “Audible Citizenship and Audiomobility: Race, Technology, and CB Radio,” *American Quarterly* 63, no. 3 (Sept. 2011): 531–53; Kristen Haring, *Ham Radio’s Technical Culture* (Cambridge, MA, 2008); Susan J. Douglas, *Listening In: Radio and the American Imagination: From Amos ‘n’ Andy and Edward R. Murrow to Wolfman Jack and Howard Stern* (New York, 1999).

⁵³On the connections between gaming and hacking, see Colin Milburn, *Respawn: Gamers, Hackers, and Technogenic Life* (Durham, 2018). On gaming and exclusion, Aaron Trammell, *The Privilege of Play: A History of Hobby Games, Race, and Geek Culture* (New York, 2024); Megan Condis, *Gaming Masculinity: Trolls, Fake Geeks, and the Gendered Battle for Online Culture* (Iowa City, 2018); and Shira Chess, *Ready Player Two: Women Gamers and Designed Identity* (Minneapolis, 2017).

ignored or poorly designed.”⁵⁴ Phreaking allowed its practitioners to claim social status they otherwise lacked. Steve Wozniak would later describe his time phone phreaking as a period in which he was a technical “leader,” a pioneer “doing something that nobody would really believe was possible.”⁵⁵ While Wozniak was a student at the University of California, Berkeley, he partnered with Steve Jobs to make and sell Blue Boxes to other students in his college dormitory. With each box, the duo included a paper slip that read “you have the world in your hands.”⁵⁶ All phreaks seemed to share this feeling when they plied the telephone system—Blue Box in hand.

Though communities of phreaks remained mostly white and male, their collaborative and competitive pursuits did not exclude others as a rule. Susy “Thunder” Headley, one of the few women involved, recalled that “Everybody was trying to outdo everybody else to see who was greater, who was better, who had better access, who could get into the tightest or best systems.”⁵⁷ Technical prowess could mean acceptance in a community of phreaks. Phone phreaking introduced blind users to a community that welcomed their acute sense of hearing and unique interests in the Bell System. Engressia, for example, described his entry into the phreak scene as “opening up a new world.” Learning with and about “the phone,” he continued, became a “shaping force on my whole life.” With friends like phreaks, Engressia garnered a respect that U.S. society otherwise withheld.⁵⁸

Descriptions of phone phreaks as teenage pranksters and obsessive technicians dominated writing about the phenomenon early on. In 1968, media accounts stressed a tension between the passive love of a hobby and an active embrace of that hobby’s political significance, between views of the Bell System as a virtual playpen for testing a phreak’s telephonic prowess and as a proving ground for political action. In the late 1960s, *Wall Street Journal* columnist Ronald Kessler described phreaks as young men and “engineer types” who wanted to prove that “the system’ can be beaten.” Free calls were simply a “fringe benefit.” Crucially, the columnist contrasted this movement of “free phoners” and their relentless pursuit to “outfox” the telephone company with the visible sit-ins, be-ins, and love-ins of the 1960s youth movements.⁵⁹ Technical challenges and pursuits, he concluded, stood beyond politics. Within the next several years, however, the Yuppies appropriated phreaking as a tool of political protest.

Phreaky Politics

In 1971, Abbie Hoffman and a Cornell University engineering major, Alan Fierstein, writing under the pseudonym Al Bell, co-founded the *Youth International Party Line (YIPL)*. *YIPL* sought to make phone phreaking into a new tool on the New Left. The Bell System was not viewed favorably among the phone phreaks publishing *YIPL*. In its first issue, the editors described their purpose as educating the American public about the “phone company’s part in the war against the poor, the non-white, the non-conformist.” The Bell System was against “the people,” and *YIPL*’s editors encouraged readers to share the magazine with friends, colleagues,

⁵⁴Ronald Kessler, “Telephone Operators: Ingenious Young Men Outfox Phone Firms,” *Wall Street Journal*, Jan. 10, 1968, 1.

⁵⁵Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*; Steve Wozniak and Gina Smith, *IWoz: Computer Geek to Cult Icon: How I Invented the Personal Computer, Co-Founded Apple, and Had Fun Doing It* (New York, 2006).

⁵⁶Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*. As Jobs would tell his biographer much later, “there wouldn’t have been an Apple” without the Blue Box. See Walter Isaacson, *Steve Jobs* (New York, 2015), 30.

⁵⁷“Testimony of Susan Headley, Tujunga, Calif.,” in U.S. Congress, Senate, Committee on Governmental Affairs, *Computer Security in the Federal Government and the Private Sector: Hearings before the Subcommittee on Oversight of Government Management of the Committee on Governmental Affairs*, 98 Cong. 1st sess., Oct. 25 and 26, 1983, 24.

⁵⁸R. Volvox, “Phone Phreaks: Ripping Off Pa Bell,” *Fifth Estate* 7, no. 19 (Dec. 1972), 8. Engressia was not the only blind phreak. Others, like Bill Acker and Denny Teresil, shared this sense of community among phreaks. On the Bell System and disability, broadly considered, see Harry G. Lang, *A Phone of Our Own: The Deaf Insurrection Against Ma Bell* (Washington, D.C., 2000).

⁵⁹Kessler, “Telephone Operators,” 1.

and local libraries.⁶⁰ By invoking the “party line,” a practice of sharing telephone service between households in rural America, the editors evoked ideas of community-led technology.⁶¹

“YIPL is a Public Service,” stated an August 1971 statement of purpose. Its function was to “bridge the communications gap” between Americans by “spread[ing] any information” that was blocked by “monopolies like THE BELL SYSTEM.” “For those of you who don’t understand exactly who the hell we are, let me make one thing perfectly clear,” *YIPL*’s editors wrote: “We are not them.” Readers were encouraged to reproduce useful pieces from the magazine and distribute copies at “strategic locations,” to tell their friends, to write articles for *YIPL*, and to share articles with any “half-decent paper” in the reader’s town.⁶² Later issues “authorized” every reader to represent *YIPL* and encouraged them to prepare radio programs on “phone politics and technology” for local stations.⁶³

Alongside organizations and publications on the New Left, *YIPL* mobilized ideas widespread in postwar counterculture about the individual as the primary unit of political activity, a person whose malleable identity could be remade in the image of tomorrow’s politics. When Hoffman wrote that phreaks were “America’s last great inventors,” he meant this technologically—and politically.⁶⁴ In *YIPL*’s pages, as in pop art and glossy magazines, politics appeared in compelling sets of beliefs ready for modification. As an early editorial in the journal instructed in a bulleted list:

YIPL is anti-corporate technology
 YIPL is how to do it
 YIPL is for you
 YIPL is you
 YIPL is you sending in articles
 YIPL is you teaching others
 YIPL is you yelling at us when we say dumb things
 YIPL is yelling at you when you don’t say things
 YIPL is in need of your support, and your friends
 AT&T and ITT want to catch YIPL but they know that YIPL is growing into the whole lot of
 together people that YIPL is.⁶⁵

As the magazine evolved, *YIPL*’s editors emphasized that their magazine should be a channel for a community to share information: its contents would be entirely “reader-supplied.” The goal was to make the magazine into a “centralized information pool . . . well-stocked with useful hints” about the telephone system, food system, media, and transformation networks.⁶⁶ It was also to include tips on the latest “corporation ripoffs, establishment fucks, healthful hints,” and contacts of potential readers.⁶⁷ “All useful ideas will be published,” the editors promised.⁶⁸ “You are the source of information,” instructed a later issue, forming a “radical yellow pages.”⁶⁹

⁶⁰Editorial, “We At YIPL,” *YIPL*, no. 1 (June 1971), 1.

⁶¹Lapsley, *Exploding the Phone*, 186. On the party line’s history, see Ronald R. Kline, “Resisting Consumer Technology in Rural America: The Telephone and Electrification,” in *How Users Matter: The Co-Construction of Users and Technology*, eds. Nelly Oudshoorn and Trevor Pinch (Cambridge, MA, 2003), 51–66.

⁶²Editors, “Statement of Purpose,” *YIPL*, no. 3 (Aug. 1971), 1.

⁶³Editorial note, *YIPL*, no. 10 (May 1972), 1.

⁶⁴Abbie Hoffman, “Everything You Always Wanted to Know About Phone Phreaking,” in “Phone Phreaking, undated,” box 2019-050/14, AHP.

⁶⁵“YIPL Is,” *YIPL*, no. 19 (June 1973), 2.

⁶⁶Editors, “Statement of Purpose,” *YIPL*, no. 5 (Nov. 1971), 1.

⁶⁷Editorial note, *YIPL*, no. 8 (Feb. 1972), 1.

⁶⁸Editors, “Statement of Purpose,” *YIPL*, no. 5 (Nov. 1971), 1.

⁶⁹Editors, “1972 Credit Card Code,” *YIPL*, no. 7 (Dec.-Jan. 1972), 1.

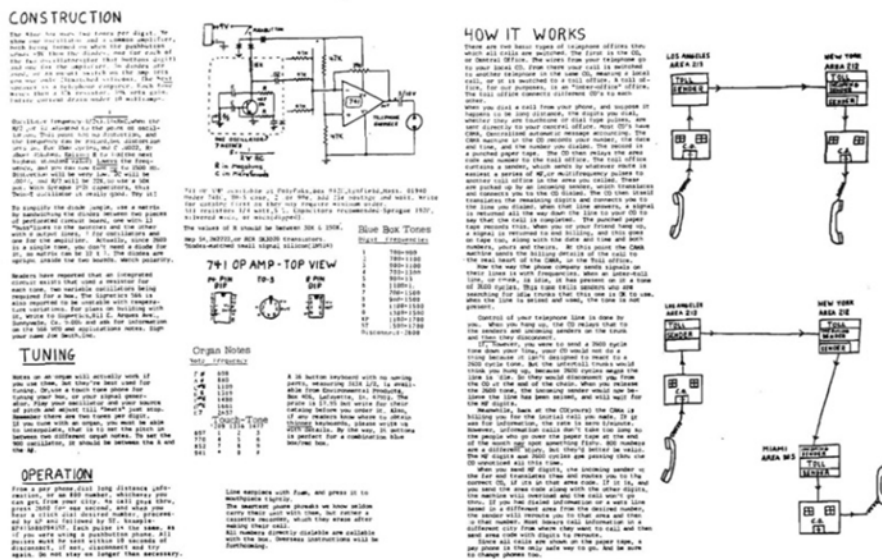


Figure 2. A diagram for constructing a blue box from the August 1972 (no. 12) issue of *Youth International Party Line*, the foremost publication on phone phreaking in the 1970s.
Source: Youth International Party Line, August 1972 (no. 12), 2.

Phreaking itself was styled as a universal tool. “Anyone can be a phone phreak, regardless of technical knowledge,” Hoffman wrote. “You need not be a certain age, sex, or anything,” and—better still—Hoffman wrote that “every phone phreak gets away with it.”⁷⁰ Readers were encouraged to support *YIPL* by “reprinting” and distributing it to friends, while always keeping a “stock of Xeroxed copies” ready-to-hand for would-be Yuppies. Put differently, “When you get the shit, be sure to duplicate it immediately.”⁷¹

Beyond reproducing articles, readers were encouraged to plug *YIPL* into the decentralized network of activist and countercultural instructions flowering on the New Left. A May 1972 missive admonished readers to “START YOUR OWN LOCAL CHAPTER OF YIP!” Holding workshops, “information drives,” educational meetings, or other convenings with health clinics, food coops, libraries, headshops, day care facilities, radio stations, newspapers, bookstores, and local television and radio stations or “any communications medium that reaches many people” was encouraged.⁷²

The magazine featured hundreds of diagrams, guides, and parts lists for the building of multifrequency devices phone phreaks used. (Figure 2) Beyond construction manuals, it published guides to manipulating telephone operators, using stolen credit card codes, and cheating utilities and the Postal Service on bills. Other articles instructed readers in a range of low-tech hacks to circumvent paying at pay phones, parking meters, and vending machines—using everything from #14 washers, ice, and bottle caps to fool meters and Ma Bell—and to lower utility meter bills, make fake IDs, and pick locks. In the early 1970s, one *YIPL* contributor named Jack Flash described the phreak philosophy, in part, as prolonged “underground warfare against mindless mechanical bandits.”⁷³ The Bell System personified monopolistic corporations and government power alike. Thus, as Hoffman explained in an early issue, these were not mere

⁷⁰Hoffman, “Everything You Always Wanted to Know About Phone Phreaking,” in “Phone Phreaking, undated,” box 2019-050/14, AHP.

⁷¹Editorial note, *YIPL*, no. 9 (Mar.-Apr. 1972), 1.

⁷²Editorial note, *YIPL*, no. 10 (May 1972), 1.

⁷³Jack Flash, "Hot Flashes," *YIPL*, no. 19 (June 1973), 1.

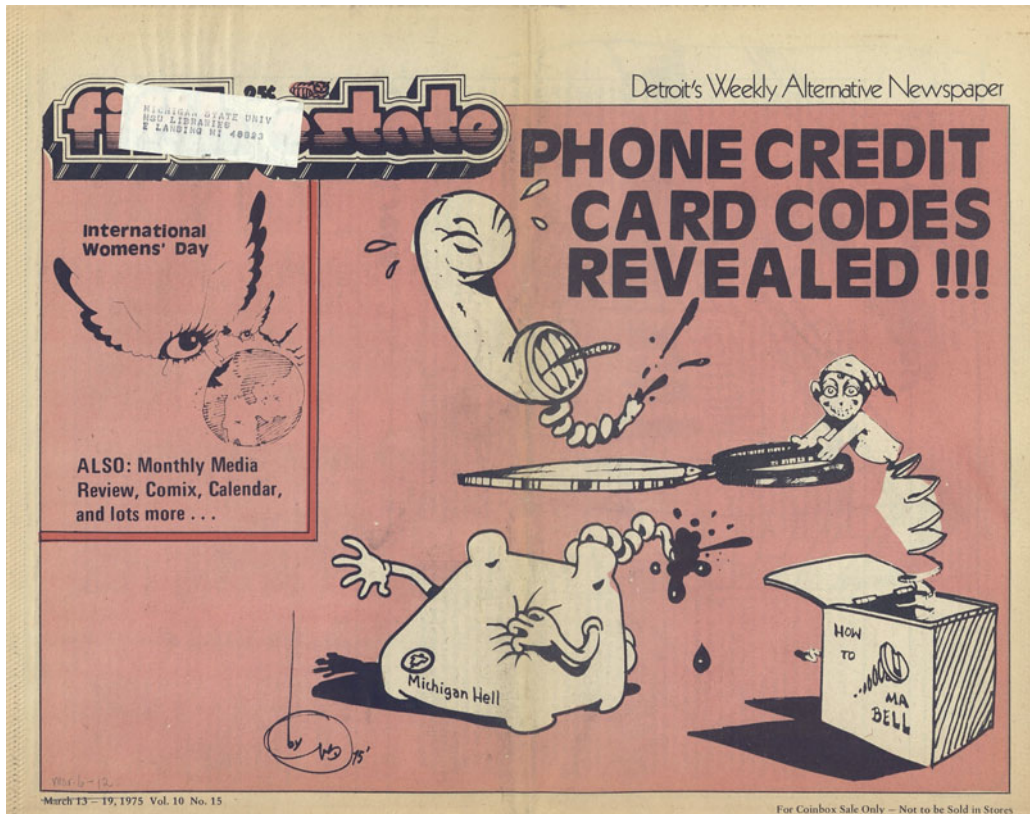


Figure 3. Cover image from the March 1975 (vol. 10, no. 15) issue of *Fifth Estate*, a new left affiliated magazine produced in and distributed from Detroit, Michigan.

Source: *Fifth Estate* 10, no. 15 (March 13, 1975), cover page.

schemes for free stuff; they were practices for actualizing “pay phone justice,” strategies for accessing public services.⁷⁴

In the wider remit of New Left publications, information about phone phreaking was depicted simultaneously as the schematics for malicious pranks and the information required for technical mastery. In the Detroit-based magazine *The Fifth Estate*, for example, readers encountered phreaks as malicious pranksters ripping off the system (Figure 3) in the form of a jack-in-the-box clown. Popping out of a crate labeled “how to screw Ma Bell” and brandishing scissors, the phreak cuts the cord of a hissing Michigan Bell telephone. Other images depicted phreaks as adventurous musketeers “taming the telephone beast” (Figure 4). And *Ramparts Magazine* (Figure 5), the muckraking zine published out of San Francisco, published a guide to the Blue Box as a tool “virtually anyone and everyone” could use, providing all Americans with the opportunity to “regulate” the phone company at home.⁷⁵ In all three, the Bell System’s telephones were stylized as technological monsters deserving of regulation and democratic oversight.

These efforts to exploit the Bell System related to the Yippies’ previous attempts to manipulate the American media environment. *YIPL* was an extension of the New Left’s Youth International Party (YIP). YIP’s leaders advocated for politics led by youth using gimmicks,

⁷⁴Abbie Hoffman, “On Pay Phone Justice . . .” *YIPL*, no. 4 (Sept. 1971), 2.

⁷⁵Ray Oklahoma, “Regulating The Phone Company In Your Home,” *Ramparts* (June 1972). On *Ramparts*, see Peter Richardson, *A Bomb In Every Issue: How the Short, Unruly Life of Ramparts Magazine Changed America* (New York, 2009).



Figure 4. Image from an August 1974 (vol. 9, no. 13) issue of *Fifth Estate*, a New Left affiliated magazine produced in and distributed from Detroit, Michigan, depicting the Blue Box as a tool to "tame" the Bell System.

Source: Dennis Witkowski, "Taming the Telephone Beast," *Fifth Estate* 9, no. 13 (August 22, 1974), 9-10.

pranks, and media-grabbing tactics and guided by aspirations toward alternative ideals and institutions. The party member, or "Yippie," would become a multipurpose activist in an era defined by new media. As Hoffman wrote, "If the press had created 'hippie,' could not we five hatch the 'yippie'?"⁷⁶ The recurring theme of YIP's activities became testing the relationship between protest and the media environment. "The commercial is information," Hoffman wrote in his 1968 manifesto, *Revolution for the Hell of It*, and information in a mass-consumerist

⁷⁶Anderson, *The Movement and the Sixties*, 217.

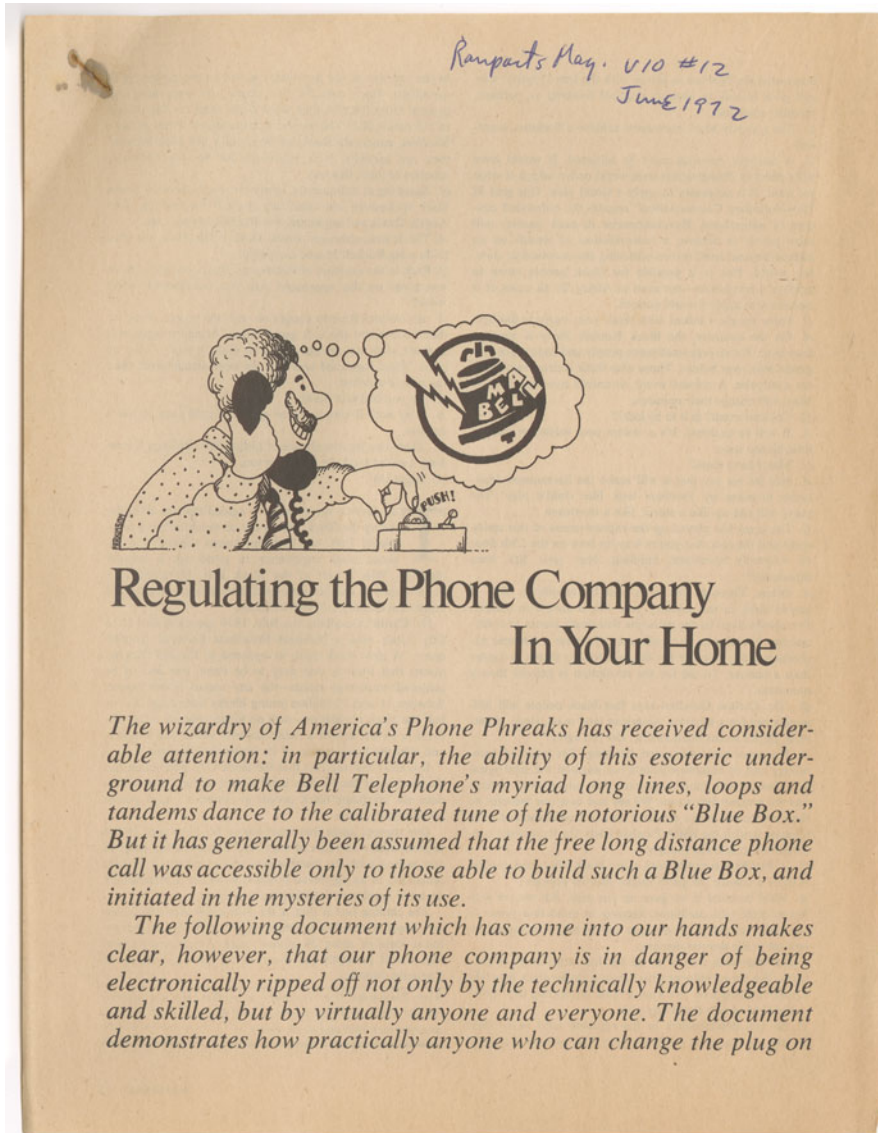


Figure 5. The article header for Roy Oklahoma's 1972 article in *Ramparts* vol. 10, no. 12.

Source: Roy Oklahoma, "Regulating The Phone Company in Your Home," in "Legal Dope," box 2019-050/14, AHP. Photo: camh-dob-035241_0001, Dolph Briscoe Center for American History.

media environment could be manipulated.⁷⁷ Within Hoffman's writing was an early insight about virality: "Media is free," he argued. "Use it. Don't pay for it. Don't buy ads. Make news."⁷⁸

The Yippies' aspiration to make news and manipulate attention manifested in grand media-grabbing gimmicks. The first, an October 1967 anti-Vietnam War march on the Pentagon, ended with Hoffman proposing to "levitate" the Pentagon and perform an exorcism of its "evil spirits."⁷⁹ New journalist Norman Mailer reported on the march in *The Armies of the Night*, where he described the throngs of Yippies as "legions of Sgt. Pepper's Band," suspended between

⁷⁷Hoffman, *Revolution for the Hell of It*, 133-4.

⁷⁸*Ibid.*, 44.

⁷⁹Isserman and Kazin, *America Divided*, 184.

reality and fiction, between “history and the comic book, between legend and television, the Biblical archetypes and the movies.”⁸⁰ “The aesthetic at last was the politics,” Mailer wrote.⁸¹ Yippie Jerry Rubin argued much the same when he declared that “Rebellion begins on your face.”⁸² Appearance, lifestyle, and aesthetics became political terrain. According to one popular countercultural refrain, “The revolution is the way you live your life.”⁸³

A year later, in protest of the 1968 Democratic National Convention’s “Convention of Death,” the Yippies held a “Festival of Life.” There, the movement’s leaders, or lead provocateurs, stressed a do-it-yourself politics premised on radical permissibility: “Amerika says: *Don’t!* The Yippies say *Do It!*” For the Yippies, the *it* was often absurd, contradictory, and far flung. “Free Speech is the Right to Shout ‘Theater’ in a Crowded Fire,” they advised. Theatrics, they hoped, would become “myth” and create “free advertising.”⁸⁴ Absurd acts themselves, Hoffman explained, worked to “disrupt the image” of an “orderly society.”⁸⁵ These tactics were displayed in Chicago, where the Yippies paraded a 145-pound domestic pig, Pigasus the Immortal, around town as a presidential candidate.⁸⁶ “If we can’t have him in the White House,” the Yippies declared, “we can have him for breakfast.”⁸⁷

For the Yippies, pranks, stunts, and gimmicks were substantive political actions that laid claim on public authority.⁸⁸ At the Chicago Convention, the Yippies circulated a list of broad demands that reflected everything from particular policy preferences to expansive revolutionary ideals: these included an end to the Vietnam War, full employment, the legalization of drugs, freedom for all Americans regardless of skin color, the abolition of money, widespread birth control, and new sexual liberation. A blank space for “what you want” invited readers to write themselves into politics.⁸⁹

The yawning gap between the specificity of some demands and the impossibly vague parameters of others permeated the Yippie approach to politics. At its best, this approach sourced political priorities from the crowd. As Yippie activist Judy Gumbo reminisced on the movement, Yippie strategy was essentially “anarchy with discipline.”⁹⁰ At its worst, however, critics alleged that Yippies represented the vague demands of drug-induced mobs and vacuous lifestyle consumers. Memoirs from the period suggest a universal apprehension of cracks in the social, political, and economic conventions that defined postwar American life. All signs suggested that the center would not hold. With characters like the Yippies in the headlines, journalist Joan Didion was right to observe that “Disorder was its own point.”⁹¹

There can be no doubt that the Yippies dealt in political theater and drummed up disorder, but their dramatized departures from the American establishment were creative responses to a political landscape that appeared quite bleak, domestically and abroad. The Yippies saw the Bell System as a monopoly bringing the world to the brink. And by *YIPL*’s founding, those on the

⁸⁰Norman Mailer, *The Armies of the Night: History as a Novel, the Novel as History* (New York, 1968), 108–9.

⁸¹*Ibid.*, 91–2.

⁸²Jerry Rubin, *We Are Everywhere* (New York, 1971), 42.

⁸³Robert C. Cottrell, *Sex, Drugs, and Rock ’n’ Roll: The Rise of America’s 1960s Counterculture* (Lanham, MD, 2015), 221.

⁸⁴Anderson, *The Movement and the Sixties*, 218–9. “Do it!” would become a Yippie slogan and the title of Jerry Rubin’s radical memoir and manifesto, *Do it! Scenarios of the Revolution* (New York, 1970).

⁸⁵Raskin, *For the Hell of It*, 143.

⁸⁶Frank Kusch, *Battleground Chicago: The police and the 1968 Democratic National Convention* (Chicago, 2008), 60; James Tracy, *Direct Action: Radical Pacifism from the Union Eight to the Chicago Seven* (Chicago, 1996).

⁸⁷Associated Press, “Chicago Cops Squelch Piggy Nominations,” *The Montreal Gazette*, Aug. 23, 1968, 2.

⁸⁸Julie Stephens, *Anti-Disciplinary Protest: Sixties Radicalism and Postmodernism* (Cambridge, 1998).

⁸⁹Anderson, *The Movement and the Sixties*, 219; Abbie Hoffman, *Soon to Be a Major Motion Picture* (New York, 1980), 144–7; Hoffman, *Revolution for the Hell of It*, 37; Rubin, *Do It!*, 81–6, 161–7.

⁹⁰Judy Gumbo, *Yippie Girl: Exploits in Protest and Defeating the FBI* (New York, 2022), 6.

⁹¹Joan Didion, *The White Album* (New York, 1979), 37, 134; Joan Didion, *Slouching Toward Bethlehem* (New York, 1968).

New Left had sharpened four critiques of the Bell System's role within the wider American political system: its ties to the military-industrial complex, then embroiled in controversies over the war in Vietnam; its labor and business practices; reports of its surveillance practices; and the supposed conformity within its workplace. Phone phreaking, in turn, was styled as a tool to resist four forces within the American system.

Ma Bell at War, at Home, and Abroad

In the late 1960s and early '70s, the New Left's most salient critique of the Bell System focused on its ties to the U.S. government and the war in Vietnam. AT&T was one of the key beneficiaries of wartime booms in federal spending and a cornerstone of the military-industrial research system developed in the post-WWII period, to the extent that one journalist described the research relationship between the company and the government as a "marriage." During World War II, Bell Laboratories designed, and Western Electric built, many of the cutting-edge technologies deployed in theaters of war. At home, Bell built U.S. missile defense systems, including Project Nike and the Safeguard Program, and constructed a private military telephone network, known as AUTOVON, that would ensure the "survivability" of the U.S. government and allow the president to deliver a "doomsday signal" to mobilize the United States' missiles in the event of widespread nuclear warfare.⁹² Bell's relationship with the Pentagon was so close, in fact, that secretaries of defense and Pentagon officials occasionally blocked antitrust efforts targeting AT&T because of its central role in military infrastructure, especially the nuclear stockpile at facilities like Sandia National Laboratories.⁹³ It is perhaps unsurprising, then, that when social critic Lewis Mumford searched for a name for the ever-growing system of technologies mediating and controlling society in the late 1960s, he landed on "the Pentagon of Power."⁹⁴ It was no coincidence that Western Electric, the "Makers of Bell Telephones," were also the "Managers of the Nation's Nuclear Stockpile."⁹⁵

If Bell's connection to the state was clear at home, it was glaringly obvious if Americans looked for evidence abroad. Starting in 1966, American consumers protested a 10% telephone excise tax that the government imposed to finance the Vietnam War. In 1967, the Committee on Nonviolent Action estimated that, combined with a 1% excise tax on automobiles, the U.S. telephone tax would raise \$1.2 billion in the 1967 fiscal year. The Committee translated this sum into "about twenty days of killing in Vietnam."⁹⁶

Protests against the telephone company's connection to Vietnam coincided with historic labor action against AT&T. In the 1970s, AT&T was the largest employer of women in the United States. Over half of its total employees were women. Though 99.9% of Bell operators were women, these employees were systematically excluded from management and craft jobs. In 1970, the Equal Employment Opportunity Commission (EEOC) petitioned the Federal Communications Commissions to reject a rate increase proposed by AT&T. The EEOC's aim was to pressure Ma Bell to end its practice of exclusively hiring women for specific low-rung jobs

⁹²For overviews, see Janet Abbate, *Inventing the Internet* (Cambridge, MA, 1999), 13–7; Garrett M. Graff, *Raven Rock: The Story of the U.S. Government's Secret Plan to Save Itself—While the Rest of Us Die* (New York, 2018). For specific quotes and historical documents, see E.S. Hoover and R.A. Jacoby, "Safeguard Data-Processing System," Safeguard Supplement, *The Bell System Technical Journal* (Jan. 1975): 181–9; J.W. Gorgas, "Autovon, switching network for global defense," *Bell Laboratories Record* 46 (Apr. 1968): 106–11; William J. Broad, "Nuclear Pulse (II): Ensuring Delivery of the Doomsday Signal," *Science* 212, no. 4499 (June 1981): 1116–20.

⁹³William J. Broad, "Nuclear Pulse (I): Awakening the Chaos Factor," *Science* 212, no. 4498 (May 1981): 1009–12. Butler and Adams, *Manufacturing the Future*, 148–9. On Sandia, see Necah Stewart, *Sandia National Laboratories: The Postwar Decade* (Albuquerque, 1990).

⁹⁴Lewis Mumford, *The Pentagon of Power: The Myth of the Machine* (New York, 1970), 183.

⁹⁵Butler and Adams, *Manufacturing the Future*, 148.

⁹⁶Schiller, *Crossed Wires*, 425.

in the company. This was well known: as journalist Sonny Kleinfeld quipped, AT&T was “the corporate personification of male chauvinism and racism.”⁹⁷ Meanwhile, the Communications Workers of America (CWA), “a powerful industrial trade union,” sought a new contract and better labor conditions amid AT&T’s nationwide transition to electronic switching—the technology that enabled phone phreaking to take off.⁹⁸

These conditions led to a CWA strike. In July 1971, over 500,000 AT&T workers declared a strike against the System. Strikers outside of Bell offices across the country printed signs demanding change: “women are relegated to the duller jobs, paid sub-standard wages, and are treated like both small children and slaves . . . Ma Bell Is a Cheap Mother!”⁹⁹ For their part, *YIPL* and other New Left publications encouraged solidarity between phone phreaks and Bell employees. “Write us,” *YIPL*’s editors instructed Bell employees, with experiences of “working for the largest, most powerful piece of shit in the world.” Examples of “sexism, racism, anti-semitism, pigism, and any other ism you can think of” were encouraged.¹⁰⁰

YIPL’s first issue went to print while the CWA strike raged on. *YIPL* quoted CWA president Joseph Beirne on the practices of surveillance within the Bell System: “[T]he telephone industry has developed equipment for monitoring its operators, its service assistants, its commercial office employees,” Beirne stated, “in short, all its employees who deal with customers.” The result, he continued, was that American customers were being “monitored at the same time.”¹⁰¹

Bell’s labor-monitoring practices aside, the possibility of wiretapping loomed large in American life. As historian Sara Igo shows, it was an “open secret” that anyone ranging from a hard-nosed detective to a Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) agent could “listen in” on American phone calls.¹⁰² As attorney Samuel Dash told a 1959 Senate subcommittee, “almost every police wiretapper, whether he be a plainclothesman or an assistant district attorney, if he is assigned to supervise wiretapping . . . has a contact in the telephone company.” This practice, he continued, was “condoned by the company itself.”¹⁰³ “The FBI plugs into Ma Bell,” someone would later write for the *Yipster Times* about the revolving door of contacts between the Bell System and American law enforcement.¹⁰⁴

Related to the Bell System’s government ties, labor practices, and role in the surveillance of citizens, the New Left saw Bell’s culture as the picture of postwar conformity. Its employee was the “organization man” incarnate, complete with a grey flannel suit.¹⁰⁵ Consider “Living in Butte with Mother Bell,” an essay about “the businessman’s dream,” working for “the grand mother of American business, the androgynous bid daddy: Ma Bell.” The writer, Rob Evans, describes his experience at the subsidiary Mountain Bell. “The Ma Bell mold presses ever more tightly about the worker,” Evans wrote. “He’s expected to work not simply at Mountain Bell or for Mountain Bell: he’s expected to work with Mountain Bell; but he must first accept the mold.”¹⁰⁶ AT&T’s executives, for their part, seemingly embraced Bell’s place in American life as the paradigmatic

⁹⁷Kleinfeld, *The Biggest Company on Earth*, 206. See also Green, *Race on the Line*, 210–1.

⁹⁸Schiller, Chapter 9, “Activists and Dissidents,” in *Crossed Wires*, 338–477.

⁹⁹Anderson, *The Movement and the Sixties*, 362.

¹⁰⁰“Bell Employees!!!” *YIPL*, no. 3 (Aug. 1971), 1.

¹⁰¹Editorial, “Our Friendly Phone Company . . .” *YIPL*, no. 1 (June 1971), 3.

¹⁰²Sarah E. Igo, *The Known Citizen: A History of Privacy in Modern America* (Cambridge, MA, 2018), 114, 170; Brian Hochman, *The Listeners: A History of Wiretapping in the United States* (Cambridge, MA, 2022).

¹⁰³Dash would later preside as the chief counsel of the Senate Watergate Committee amid the fallout of the Nixon administration’s telephone-centered scandal. “Testimony of Samuel Dash,” in U.S. Congress, Committee on the Judiciary, *Invasions of Privacy (Telephone Systems): Hearings before the Subcommittee on Administrative Practice and Procedure, Part 6*, 89th Cong., 2nd sess., Sept. 14, 1966, 2602.

¹⁰⁴Vinegar Ben, “FBI Plugs Into Ma Bell,” *The Yipster Times*, Aug. 1978, 26.

¹⁰⁵On these tropes in American culture, see Wilfred M. McClay, *The Masterless: Self and Society in Modern America* (Chapel Hill, 1994); and Mark Greif, *The Age of the Crisis of Man: Thought and Fiction in America, 1933–1973* (Princeton, 2015).

¹⁰⁶Rob Evans, “Living in Butte With Mother Bell,” *Borrowed Times* 4, no. 2 (Sept. 1975), 12–3.

American corporation.¹⁰⁷ In 1967, for example, a junior executive at AT&T put it explicitly: “In the office we call it ‘The System,’ and use of the word ‘the’ means dogmatic finality. The wall comes up pretty fast when you start tampering with the way things are done within The System, and you either slow down and do things Bell’s way or knock your brains out.”¹⁰⁸ Or, as a seventeen-year employee of the Bell Telephone Company wrote in a magazine article reflecting on “life in the Bell System,” “the pecking order was clear.”¹⁰⁹

Taken together, the Yippies, CWA members, phone phreaks, and social critics saw the Bell System as *the system*. This view is captured by a 1976 cover image of *The Rag*, which visualized Ma Bell as the central nervous system channeling commands from the heights of American political, economic, and cultural power. (Figure 6) It depicted Andrew Jackson authorizing Native American removal; Richard Nixon covering up the Watergate scandal; business executives thwarting labor movements; and a grotesque caricature of an operator or FBI agent listening in on sexual intercourse. The telephone pictured here was a tool of American wrongdoing across time, space, and circumstance. Ma Bell, as civil liberties advocates quipped at the time, was Big Brother’s handmaiden.¹¹⁰

Phreaks at Odds

Critiques of the Bell System in *YIPL*, *Fifth Estate*, *Ramparts*, *Borrowed Times*, and other New Left publications attracted readers for their rhetorical force and compelling imagery. In these pages, telephone lines were anatomized as the central nervous system in the body electric of an evil American empire, the tools of discipline and punishment for monopoly power, and the oppressive molding that clamped upon Americans through corporate culture and surveillance apparatuses alike. Collectively, these critiques rendered the Bell System into a symbol of the post-war American political order Hoffman and the Yippies sought to transform or topple with a microphone in one hand—and a Blue Box in the other.

From the outset, however, *YIPL*’s best-laid plans were subject to criticism from within and without. In the second issue, the magazine published journalist Russell Baker’s extended critique of Hoffman’s writing on the telephone system. “I wonder if you have really thought out the implications of the grand philosophical idea of destroying the telephone company,” Baker observed. After all, the Bell System’s very size and scope made Hoffman’s rip-offs possible. More important, Baker argued that participants in American counterculture and social movements *required* telephones. The American activist “needs a telephone the way a monkey needs a banana,” and telephones were “as much a part of his uniform as denim, dried lentils and a coiffure from Michelangelo’s Moses.” To wit, would “the next phone company,” one rebuilt after some unspecified act of destruction, tolerate the same level of activist use and fraud? Baker stated that “The present telephone company is the best of all possible telephone companies for the counter-culture.”¹¹¹

Hoffman responded by allowing part of Baker’s critique. It was true, he wrote, that “even us Yippies don’t wish to hatch our coast-to-coast conspiracies using dixie cups with waxed string stretched between them.” “As the level of technological development increases,” Hoffman suggested, the goal should be a “society free to all the people.” Such should be the role of a public

¹⁰⁷AT&T’s status comes across in Richard Langlois’s recent treatment, *The Corporation and the Twentieth Century: The History of American Business Enterprise* (Princeton, 2023).

¹⁰⁸Joseph C. Goulden, *Monopoly* (New York, 1968), 16. Other internal accounts, like former AT&T employee James B. Crawford’s *Ma Bell Is No Lady: A View from Within the System* (Pelican Publishing Co., 1987), made similarly critical references to “system.”

¹⁰⁹Alan B. Kamman, “Life in the Bell System,” *Telecommunications* (Oct. 1977), <https://memorial.bellsystem.com/lifebellsystem.htm> (accessed April 2025).

¹¹⁰Hochman, *The Listeners*, 234.

¹¹¹Russell Baker, “The Dumbest Rip-Off,” *YIPL*, no. 2 (July 1972), 2.

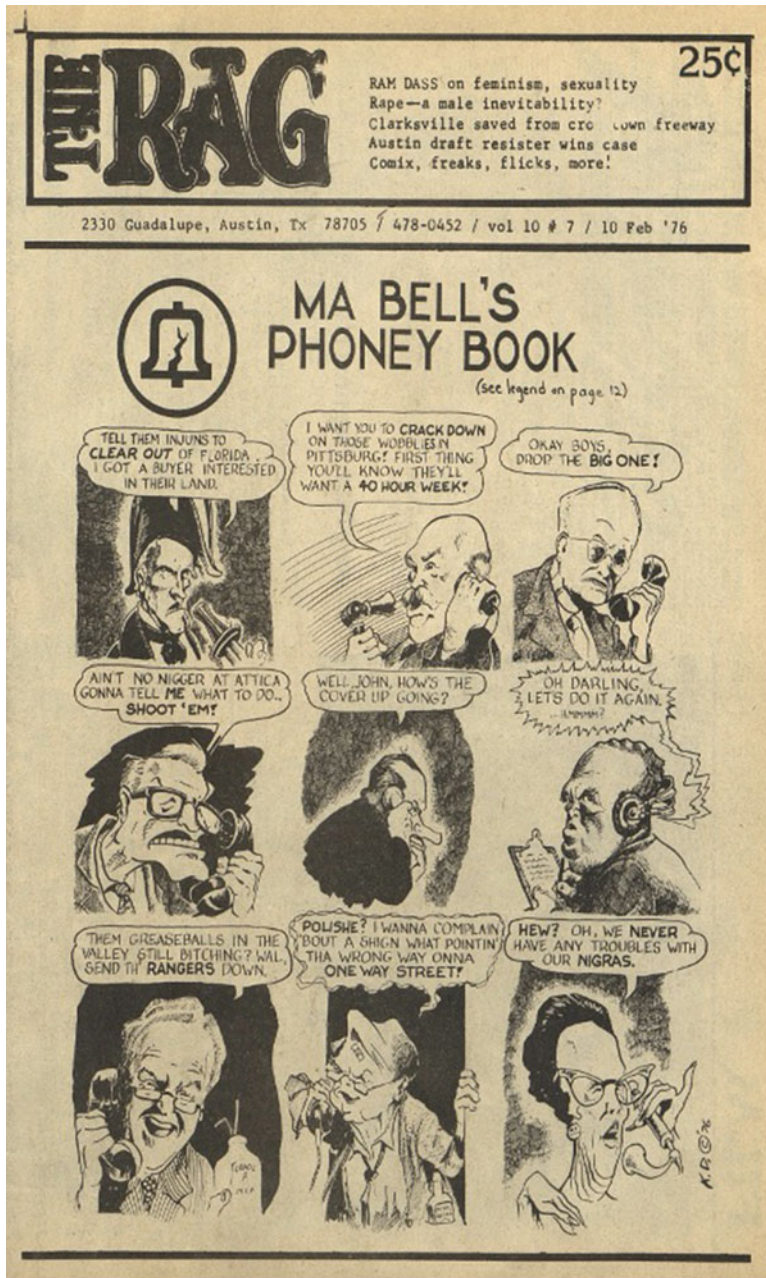


Figure 6. Cover image from the February 1976 (vol. 10, no. 7) issue of *The Rag*, a new left-affiliated magazine produced in and distributed from Austin, Texas.

Source: *The Rag* 10, no. (Februaury 10, 1976), cover page.

utility, at least to Yippies like Hoffman. “Until AT&T and the other corporations really become public services,” Hoffman asserted, “we’ll continue to rip them off every chance we get.”¹¹²

But Hoffman’s insistence revealed an instability at the heart of the Yippie-YIPL political program: what, exactly, would reconstitute the Bell System as a “public service”? Without

¹¹²Abbie Hoffman, “Dear Russell (Baker that is),” *YIPL*, no. 2 (July 1972), 2.

specifics, critiques of the Bell System relied on a reflexive critique of *anything* that appeared to be part of “the system.” The system, as such, became a floating signifier.

These tensions in *YIPL*’s critiques of AT&T were evident early on. Indeed, some *YIPL* readers went too far in their exploits. In a letter titled “Monkey Warfare,” referencing Hoffman’s *Steal This Book*, a reader suggested using a mixture of epoxy glue for “imaginative forms of protesting,” such as cementing the keyholes and coin slots in locks, parking meters, and telephones. The editors responded that readers needed to ask themselves, “How can I fuck the pigs, and help my sisters and brothers?” Indiscriminate destruction of technological infrastructure, the editors suggested, could just as easily harm an average American in need of an emergency call.¹¹³

While *YIPL*’s editors resisted the excesses of technical practices at the nexus of the New Left and phone phreaking, they often had much less to say about the interpersonal and manipulative techniques phreaks used to accomplish their goals. Besides multifrequency devices, a phreak’s greatest asset was his voice. As one phreak explained in a 1973 National Public Radio (NPR) interview, “some of the best phone phreaks don’t use any hardware at all. You can talk people in the telephone company into doing stuff for you.”¹¹⁴ Talking to and manipulating others was dubbed “social engineering” by phone phreaks. The phreak Chesire Catalyst would later describe it as follows: “Engineering is when you take a wrench to a bolt, turn it, and something happens. Social engineering is when you take a telephone, get somebody who’s dumb as a bolt on the other end, and turn it.”¹¹⁵ Or, as Hoffman wrote in his extensive notes on phreaking, “Lying is the most common phone ripoff ever invented.”¹¹⁶ To some phreaks, people were instrumental to the practice and display of their technical pursuits.

If some of *YIPL*’s early political stances emphasized empathy and solidarity with Bell employees—especially during the waves of strikes in the early 1970s—others eroded the political salience of solidaristic ties between those within the Bell System and those without. In an article on avoiding Bell fraud investigations, for example, a *YIPL* contributor suggested phreaks take an aggressive stance toward Bell employees. “If a nasty supervisor bitch calls, be nasty offensive,” a piece in *YIPL* instructed. Bell’s “special security pigs,” part of the telephone security division, “spend their full time tracking us down” and deserved even more derision if encountered.¹¹⁷ “This isn’t paranoia, it’s fucking good sense,” advised one phreak.¹¹⁸ In the Detroit-based *Fifth Estate*, Dennis Witkowski advised readers about making free calls by being “aggressively persistent” and “demanding” an immediate connection to the requested number. If the operator refused, Witkowski advised readers to try and “threaten to destroy the phone booth and demonstrate your sincerity” by “banging the receiver on the glass while shouting angry curses.” If the operator hung up, you could always “try again with a different operator.”¹¹⁹

The tension between Yippie aspirations and the realities of phreaking were highlighted by the performance of social engineering. The key to fooling telephone operators, *YIPL* and other New Left publications advised, was the sound of professionalism. Approximate the verbal behaviors of “Mr. or Mrs. Pig Businessperson,” advised a different publication.¹²⁰ Perform “like the

¹¹³Letter and editorial response, “Monkey Warfare,” *YIPL*, no. 4 (Sept. 1971), 3.

¹¹⁴Jim Russell, “Sorry, The Telephone Company You’re Dialing Has Been Temporarily Disconnected,” 16, Washington, DC: National Public Radio, Jan. 1973.

¹¹⁵SN, Chesire Catalyst, and Emmanuel Goldstein, “Social Engineering,” Hackers on Planet Earth (HOPE), Hotel Pennsylvania, New York City, Aug. 13–14, 1994, http://archive.org/details/HOPE-1-Social_Engineering (accessed Apr. 25, 2025), 1:00:02.

¹¹⁶Hoffman, “Legal Dope,” in “Phone Phreaking, undated,” box 2019-050/14, AHP, 34.

¹¹⁷“How Not to Get Caught Making Fake Credit Card Calls,” *YIPL*, no. 5 (Nov. 1971), 2.

¹¹⁸“Letters + Answers,” *YIPL*, no. 5 (Nov. 1971), 2.

¹¹⁹Dennis Witkowski, “Taming the Telephone Beast,” *Fifth Estate* 6, no. 3 (Aug. 1974), 8–9.

¹²⁰“How Not to Get Caught Making Fake Credit Card Calls,” *YIPL*, no. 5 (Nov. 1971), 3.

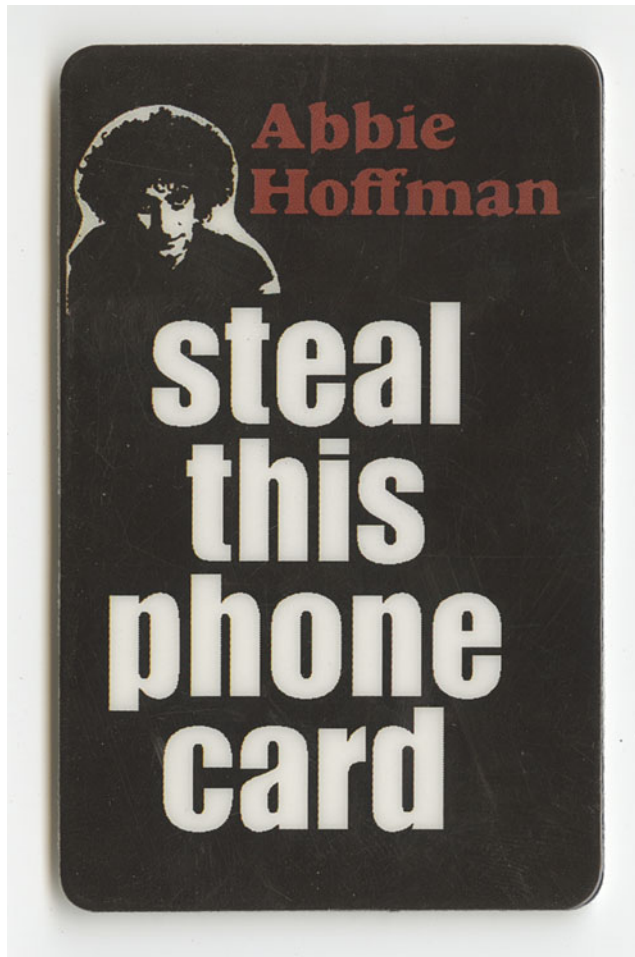


Figure 7. A wallet sized “Steal This Phone Card” from the 1970s/’80s.

Source: “Steal this phone card,” in AHP. Photo: camh-dob-035263_0001, Dolph Briscoe Center for American History, The University of Texas at Austin.

distinguished businessperson.”¹²¹ As a column in *YIPL* summarized it, “Always sound middle-aged, and in a hurry and pissed at operators, but willing to give her one chance.”¹²² Hoffman also described how would-be phreaks could use readily available distinct code number (DCN) and code letters—to say nothing of laminated, wallet-sized guides titled “Steal This Phone Card,” complete with a picture of Hoffman himself (Figure 7)—to determine telephone credit card information with ease.¹²³ The most important trick was to convince operators of one’s identity. In a “firm, business-like tone,” Hoffman offered instructions down to the pacing and intonation of phreaking: “Operator this is a credit card call,” a phreak should state. “My credit card number is _ _ _ (pause) _ _ _ (pause) _ _ _ (pause) _.” Providing or faking individual names, phone booth numbers, and the name and city of the business would assuage the operator of any doubts.

¹²¹“1978 Phone Codes Call-Long Distance,” *Fifth Estate* 13, no. 1 (Jan. 1978), 7.

¹²²“Greetings,” *YIPL*, no. 14 (Nov. 1972), 3.

¹²³ Abbie Hoffman, “Credit Cards: The Old Standby,” in “Phone Phreaking, undated,” box 2019-050/14, AHP, 11-2. At the time, DCNs and code letters could be readily found in printed pocket-sized credit card guides. Take one of the Pentagon’s phone numbers, Hoffman suggested: (202) 697-7072. If a phreak dropped the area code and added the 032 DCN for Washington and the letter R—both bits of information a user could find in ready-to-hand guides—she would have the Pentagon’s telephone credit card number: 697-7072/032/R.

Above all, never “panic and hang up,” Hoffman wrote, press forward in a “mildly impatient and condescending” tone, and all would be smooth sailing.¹²⁴

While techniques of social engineering signaled cracks in the foundation of solidarity between Yippies, phone phreaks, and Bell System employees, they also represented a new fulfillment of the old aspiration toward media manipulation demonstrated in Yippie feats of the late 1960s. Manipulation of the media environment toward political or prank-worthy ends was the Yippie’s signature move, and the telephone was nothing if not an integral component of the American media infrastructure. But what component parts of the media environment required manipulation? Were there meaningful differences between a news anchor and a telephone operator? If the Yippies saw in media the power to activate the American people—if readers were to take seriously that “YIPL is you”—the wanton manipulation of others seemingly undermined trust between parties and prevented the possibility of working together.

By 1973, these tensions were clear to any close reader. As the catalog of *YIPL* content swelled with aggressive phone phreak techniques and reflexive hatred of the system, some readers wrote to insist on a more complicated reality. In July 1973, a phreak named Nancy in Denver urged phreaks to “remember that the phone co’s lackeys are poor and starving like u, probably hate the phone co. as much as we do, and also are being exploited by it. They aren’t the enemy.”¹²⁵ The totalizing image of Ma Bell as the Phone “Kompany,” Nancy suggested, oversimplified a complex arrangement of companies and communities of employees who depended on regular paychecks.

Such tensions were no less visible when phreaks gathered later that year at the third annual phone phreak convention. There, a correspondent for *The Guardian* contrasted phreaks merely interested in telephones with “technological hippies,” such as the phreaks writing for *YIPL*, who saw Ma Bell as a monopolistic public enemy. To the journalist, however, the “‘Bell Telephone System’ as such doesn’t exist.” It was, as readers like Nancy suggested, a conglomerate of separate companies working in conjunction, rather than a malicious, monopolistic octopus wrapping its tentacles around all facets of American life.¹²⁶

When *YIPL*’s editors changed in 1973, the line between the technical and Yippie genres of phone phreaking shifted. Hoffman stepped back from his role at *YIPL*, most likely to pursue other projects. Shortly after, the magazine changed its name to *TAP*, an acronym for the Technological American Party and, later, the Technological Assistance Program. The editors described *TAP*’s purpose as that of “a people’s warehouse of technological information.”¹²⁷ As *TAP*’s editors refined a new editorial line, they purported to abandon politics altogether: *TAP* “is no longer Technological American Party. *TAP* is *TAP*. We are not a political party. We do not advocate anything, as an organization.” The journal would simply print any technical information that was otherwise “unavailable or unclear,” with priority for any information the editors deemed helpful to the “most readers.”¹²⁸ But politics is never far from technology. A potent strain resonant with the New Right soon reared its head in *TAP*’s pages.

The Changing Politics of Phreaking

Later that year, in December of 1973, a *TAP* reader recommended a catalog of electronics, surveillance units, weapons, law enforcement gadgets, and police equipment published by the group American Colonial Armament. “It’s a little right wingy in tone,” the reader observed, but it covered

¹²⁴Hoffman, “Credit Cards: The Old Standby,” in “Phone Phreaking, undated,” box 2019-050/14, AHP, 12-3.

¹²⁵Nancy, “YIPL-,” *YIPL*, no. 20 (July 1973), 2.

¹²⁶Simon Winchester, “Phone Phreaks Hold a Convention,” *The Guardian*, Oct. 7, 1973, G1.

¹²⁷Editorial, *TAP*, no. 21 (Aug.-Sept. 1973), 1.

¹²⁸Opening editorial, *TAP*, no. 25 (Jan.-Feb. 1974), 1.

“just about everything Abbie mentions in *Steal This Book*.”¹²⁹ As the 1970s wore on and *TAP* attempted to uphold its status as a non-political entity, resonances between the Yippie style of politics and an ascendant conservative coalition grew louder. Old *YIPL* critiques of the Bell System morphed into libertarian critiques of the state and an anti-establishment political culture.

By the mid-1970s, some phreaks described their technical practices in a distinctly libertarian political vernacular. When a new *TAP* editor Jim Phelps, for example, styled his schematics for the “Fone Fucker”—a device for reminting up to 300 pennies per hour into dime-sized coins, all to fool pay phones—he described himself in a tradition of agitators who debased the state’s currency and “preceded its collapse.” But Phelps could hardly explain the sweep of the historical pattern he referenced in a short column in *TAP*. He recommended that readers turn to “anti-Amerikan-Establishment authors like Hayek, Hazlett, Rothbard, and von Mises.”¹³⁰ Thereafter, “Mr. Phelps” penned a regular column featuring militias, weapons, currencies, and body armor outfitters. Other readers wrote in to recommend magazines like *Car & Driver* as “one of the most libertarian straight publications I’ve seen.”¹³¹ In turn, *TAP* became something of a recommendation algorithm for 1970s magazines catering to (mostly male) readers with the intoxicating thematic brew of heroic adventuring, masculine consumerism, war in exotic territories, and sexual conquest.¹³²

Meanwhile, by the mid-1970s, reporting and commentary on the women within *TAP* hit a wall. In 1976, *TAP* editor Tom Edison pleaded for any sign of female readership. “Surely somewhere out there in our readership,” he wrote, “are wives, sisters, girlfriends, and lovers who either are or know phone operators.” Sharing information with *TAP*, Edison suggested, would be a political act. “You’ll be doing a hell of a lot more for Women’s Lib than you even realize!”¹³³ But women readers, if there were any, failed to furnish a single letter, column, or piece of commentary while Edison and Phelps held sway.

Instead, contributors like Phelps pressed ahead with references to libertarian politics, free markets, and post-state futures. “Not only is a diamond ‘forever,’” he wrote, “so is the free market.”¹³⁴ In the apocalyptic or survivalist future Phelps envisioned, readers would need tools to survive. Hence, in an editorial entitled “Your Mission: Join Radio Free America,” Phelps wrote to celebrate the growth of amateur “guerilla radio” stations in the United States. Phelps fantasized about broadcasting John Galt’s speech from *Atlas Shrugged* during New York City’s electricity “blackouts” in the late 1970s. While Americans listened with battery-powered transistor radios for news, they would hear Ayn Rand’s Galt explain “what is wrong with The System and what can be done about it.” Referencing E. M. Forster’s science fiction and Roberto Vacca’s speculation about the next “dark age,” Phelps wrote that blackouts would continue until “the Final Blackout—when The System collapses of its own technological complexity and interdependence.”¹³⁵ Phelps lambasted readers to remember their role in the debates about the system. “And what are YOU doing, dear reader, to reduce YOUR dependence on the collapsing System?” Phelps implored *TAP*

¹²⁹Letter from a reader in Ohio, “Dear *TAP*,” *TAP*, no. 24 (Dec. 1973), 3.

¹³⁰Mr. Phelps, “*TAP* Patent Office: Fone Fucker,” *TAP*, no. 34 (Apr. 1976), 2.

¹³¹Powerbus, “Dear *TAP*,” *TAP*, no. 48 (Nov.-Dec. 1978), 2.

¹³²Notably, Phelps often referenced other period publications, like *Soldier of Fortune: The Journal of Professional Adventurers*. On this mélange of themes on the libertarian right, see Raymond Craib, *Adventure Capitalism: A History of Libertarian Exit, from the Era of Decolonization to the Digital Age* (Binghamton, 2022); and Gregory A. Daddis, *Pulp Vietnam: War and Gender in Cold War Men’s Adventure Magazines* (Cambridge, 2020).

¹³³Tom Edison, “Odds & Ends,” *TAP*, no. 35 (May 1976), 1.

¹³⁴Jim Phelps, “Ask Mr. Phelps,” *TAP*, no. 35 (May 1976), 2.

¹³⁵Jim Phelps, “Your Mission: Join Radio Free America,” *TAP*, no. 53 (Sept.-Oct. 1978), 3. On Ayn Rand’s relevance on the Right at this time, see Jennifer Burns, *Goddess of the Market: Ayn Rand and the American Right* (Oxford, 2011). On the blackouts, see G.L. Wilson and P. Zarakas, “Anatomy of a blackout: How’s and why’s of the series of events that led to the shutdown of New York’s power in July 1977,” *IEEE Spectrum* 15, no. 2 (Feb. 1978): 39–49.

readers to do more than mess with Ma Bell: “I don’t mean cheating the utility and phone companies; I mean learning to get along without them. Get into Ham and CB radio and other methods of communication. Learn about alternate sources of power.”¹³⁶

Many *TAP* contributors continued to focus on phone phreaking, but Phelps explicitly pushed readers onto other subjects. In time, *TAP*’s shifting politics obscured *YIPL*’s original focus on telecommunications and the Bell System. Phelps wrote about the “tax revolts” of the 1970s, for example, describing the efforts of libertarian investment and tax advisers like Rene Baxter, who advocated for “tax refusal.” While readers who collected “welfare or unemployment” had no need for the information, Phelps argued that everyone else ought to take note. “You have Big Brother by the BALLS!” Phelps advised: “So squeeze him like he’s been squeezing you!”¹³⁷ Later, Phelps would compare IRS agents to members of the Gestapo. Still, he advised that “FDR (ugh!) once said ‘We have nothing to fear but fear itself.’” “[D]on’t fear the IRS,” Phelps wrote, “FIGHT THEM!”¹³⁸

Efforts to decenter the Bell System became more explicit. In a 1976 editorial on the “Biggest Monopoly of All” in American politics, Phelps was even more explicit: “No, it’s not The Phone Company,” he asserted. “It’s The Establishment. Big Brother. Da Guviment,” and “Big Brother’s victims must pay whether or not they receive any ‘service.’ Payments are called ‘taxes.’” The piece likened the American revolution to a “Libertarian REVOLUTION” and compared taxes in the 1970s to those in the 1770s. “We’re as bad off now as we were under King George,” Phelps wrote. But Phelps observed that a “Second Libertarian Revolution” was taking place, one that opposed “monopolies, victimless crime laws, taxes, gov’t secrecy” and asserted that “the gov’t which governs least, governs best!!”¹³⁹ The tactics of Phelps’s “revolution” remained unclear, but a bottom-of-page reference to Western-style gang violence might have raised some reader concerns. “Do you remember in the westerns, when the Sheriff would organize a Posse,” Phelps asked. “Can’t you just see Tricky and Spiro and all the rest of them, hung by the neck, the bodies remaining for the vultures?”¹⁴⁰

When some readers expressed concern about the reemergence of politics in *TAP*, to say nothing of opposition to Mr. Phelps’ particular politics, other editors shut down the conversation. As editor Tom Edison wrote, those readers who chafed against “the light social criticism” or references to political books and magazines should look for information somewhere else. Politics and technology were inseparable, he asserted. “Stay in your room and play with your Blue Box and yourself,” Edison wrote, “and one day, when the phone goes dead and the lights go out and you finally stick your head out the door to see just what the hell is going on, don’t be surprised to find people lying on the ground dying of pollution and radiation or people being swooped up in mass arrests thanks to S-1! Remember, 1984 IS closer than you think!).” Edison went on, “I don’t know where these vegetables live but today technology depends on social, political, and economic conditions and anybody who doesn’t recognize this is a fool!” Be foolish, he concluded, and “sub to Popular Mechanix!”¹⁴¹ Even as they chastised phreaks to account for the “social, political, and economic conditions,” Edison and Phelps flattened those conditions into a binary of support for or opposition to big government. Though this libertarian turn in phreaking’s politics reflected, in some ways, a flourishing of anti-statist ideas first articulated by Hoffman, the late 1970s saw the atrophying of *TAP*’s ability to talk about politics in more complicated terms.

¹³⁶Mr. Phelps, “Ask Mr. Phelps,” *TAP*, no. 34 (Apr. 1976), 3.

¹³⁷Mr. Phelps, “Pay and Die?” *TAP*, no. 33 (Feb.-Mar. 1976), 1. On Baxter, see Robert Poole, “Spotlight, Rene Baxter,” *Reason Magazine* (Feb. 1976), <https://reason.com/1976/02/01/spotlight-rene-baxter/> (accessed Apr. 25, 2025).

¹³⁸Mr. Phelps, “A Visit from the Gestapo?” *TAP*, no. 35 (May 1976), 2.

¹³⁹Jim Phelps, “Fighting the Biggest Monopoly of All,” *TAP*, no. 39 (Sept.-Oct. 1976), 1.

¹⁴⁰“The Way It Sposed to Be,” *TAP*, no. 39 (Sept.-Oct. 1976), 1.

¹⁴¹Tom Edison, “Odds & Ends,” *TAP*, no. 35 (May 1976), 1.

Indeed, in time, allusions to violence were matched by articles on tools for committing it: guns. In fact, *TAP* editors even invoked Hoffman alongside calls to bear arms. In a 1979 issue dedicated to “Abbie Hoffman and all our other revolutionaries, wherever they are,” *TAP* editor Mr. Phelps, self-described as a “lovable, larcenous, lecherous Libertarian,” assembled an issue focusing on opposition to gun control.¹⁴² Across from the dedication to Hoffman, on the lefthand side of the front page, *TAP* displayed information from the Citizens Committee for the Right to Keep and Bear Arms, later renamed the Second Amendment Foundation, on a plan to pressure the Postal Service to issue a “pro-gun rights postage stamp.”¹⁴³ The article even included a cutout mailer to order stamps from the Committee. *TAP* thus connected its readers to one of a group of gun rights “grassroots warriors” who radicalized and mobilized Americans into the politics of “gun country” during the Cold War.¹⁴⁴

The reintroduction of politics into *TAP* was never without resistance, however. As fringe libertarian and new right organizations proliferated in the late 1970s, *TAP*’s editors occasionally voiced concern about overlaps between their readers and those communities. In a note on the “anti-semitic pro-Nazi bullshit” sold by the controversial publisher Loompanics, *TAP*’s editors observed that “many of these Free Enterprise/Survivorist types are just neo-fascists.” The editors did not intend to kick off a “big political argument,” but felt compelled to make the observation because “there are some anarcho-communist YIP type phreaks too.”¹⁴⁵ Yet *TAP*’s editors, and its readers, rarely reflected on the direction of their own publication. When they did, it was mostly halfhearted. In 1980, in a *TAP* editorial prefaced with “Politix: I know most phreax aren’t into this too much these days,” the editors argued that the “biggest danger of fascism right now comes further to the right than even Ronald Ray-gun.” The actors of concern were not survivalists, preppers, or militias, but Jerry Falwell—a “pseudo-Christian version of the Ayatollah Khomeini.”¹⁴⁶

Then too, many readers simply encouraged the libertarian turn in *TAP*’s politics. In 1977, one reader based in the United Kingdom wrote to thank *TAP* for the injection of “Libertarian stuff.” It was “exactly what I’m into politically,” the reader wrote. The material was a useful reminder that “phones aren’t everything.” “There’s only one thing a government should do for its people,” the reader went on, “and that’s to keep ’em free.”¹⁴⁷

Some readers wished for more emphasis on the themes of apocalypse and survival introduced by Phelps. John J. Williams, a *TAP* subscriber from New Mexico and president of a company called Consumertronics, wrote to *TAP* bluntly: “I think that your stuff is too esoteric,” and “most people don’t share your dislike of Ma Bell.” What would a hypothetical average reader think of *TAP* if Williams, who held an M.S. in electrical engineering and owned a consumer electronics business, “still get[s] lost on some of your articles”? *TAP*’s politics were simply unpopular: “1960s are gone,” Williams wrote, “this is ‘Looking-Out-For-No.1 Time.’” An “obsession” with utilities like AT&T, Williams wrote, would make for a “limited financial future.” The subject du jour was “SURVIVAL.” “I have found,” Williams relayed, that many American consumers had come to expect “Armed Rebellion” “Total Economic Collapse,” “and/or Foreign Power Invasion.” All these specters loomed large in the imagination of Consumertronics customers according to its owner; all signs pointed to catastrophe “very soon.” “So don’t be alarmed if they don’t get excited about credit card calls and red boxes,” Williams continued. “Change your format to reflect this change in people’s interests and objectives,” he advised, and *TAP* would

¹⁴²Editorial, “Mr. Phelps Strikes Again!” *TAP*, no. 58 (July–Aug. 1979), 1.

¹⁴³“Stamp Out Gun Control,” *TAP*, no. 58 (July–Aug. 1979), 1.

¹⁴⁴Andrew C. McKevitt, *Gun Country: Gun Capitalism, Culture & Control in Cold War America* (Chapel Hill, 2023); Pamela Haag, *The Gunning of America: Business and the Making of American Gun Culture* (New York, 2016).

¹⁴⁵Opening editorial, *TAP*, no. 54 (Nov.–Dec. 1978), 1.

¹⁴⁶RNA, “The Monthly Message,” *TAP*, no. 69 (1981), 1.

¹⁴⁷“Report from Merrie Olde England,” *TAP*, no. 43 (Mar.–Apr. 1977), 1.

surge.¹⁴⁸ 1984 did not spell the end of civilization. But that year the Bell System was broken up in a federally mandated divestiture—and *TAP*'s New York office shuttered its doors.

Phreaking's Afterlives in American Politics and Culture

TAP ceased publication in 1984. But collapse was, perhaps, unsurprising to close readers of previous issues. Throughout the mid- to late 1970s, *TAP*'s editors lamented declining subscriptions and disengaged readers. As Phelps himself put it, "the initial fascination has worn off."¹⁴⁹ Beyond faded polish, points of possible explanation for decline were plenty: the Bell System's technology improved rapidly, requiring ever-more technically sophisticated articles prone to losing reader interest; labor settlements and the end of the war in Vietnam blunted the bite of the demands that animated *YIPL* in the 1970s; editorial priorities changed such that *TAP* ventured into already saturated content spaces while leaving longtime readers, who were primarily interested in telecommunications, uncertain about the magazine's direction.

At the same time, external factors played an important role. In the late 1970s, the telephone system became harder to access. The system itself fractured into smaller units, especially after the Bell breakup in the 1980s. And a steady clip of wire fraud prosecutions discouraged would-be phone phreaks. Evolving computer technologies, too, attracted many phreaks into the new (though intimately connected) electronic playground of microcomputing. Indeed, computers were connected *through* the telephone system, offering the intellectually curious and politically active phreak new opportunities for experimentation. Yet, *TAP* seemed to miss the opportunity to explore those connections. "[T]he more we understand computers and other implements of modern societal control, the better chance we have to subvert them," one *TAP* contributor observed. But the financial and educational resources required to operate a computer meant that "there aren't many revolutionary computerfreaks." Information sharing, in the style of *YIPL* in the early 1970s, could reshape this reality. Yet *TAP*'s readers constantly wondered why the journal did not publish more on computers and computer hacking. "We have the medium (*TAP*), but WHERE'S THE INFORMATION?" The reader concluded: "WHATDAFUCK?"¹⁵⁰

But *YIPL*-turned-*TAP* was, in some ways, vexed from the beginning by its Yippie provenance. *TAP*, in this sense, shared a fate with Yippie politics writ large. By the early 1970s, the Yippies were in sharp decline. Hoffman and Rubin were no longer spokespeople.¹⁵¹ The core group of organizers devolved into a "honeycomb of cells" scattered across the country.¹⁵² Then too, shifts in the practices and perceptions of *TAP* mirrored those of Hoffman himself. As Hoffman's biographer notes, by the late 1980s, Hoffman was "increasingly part of the system." His actions looked rehearsed; his words rang hollow. It was as if he read from the script of a "movie revolutionary and a matinee idol of defiance."¹⁵³

At first, memory of *YIPL* and *TAP* fared no better. In early 1985, for example, a reader of *Popular Communications* wrote to that magazine's editors asking about the "phone phreak" publication known as *TAP*. "Have you ever heard of it?" The editor even lauded the publication as "well done." Yet the same editor lamented *TAP*'s "major shift in emphasis away from telecommunications" and toward "silly material relating to the preparation and use of street

¹⁴⁸John J. Williams, "Letter to Tom Edison," *TAP*, no. 63 (Summer 1980), 2.

¹⁴⁹Jim Phelps, "Let's Make a Deal," *TAP*, no. 39 (Sept.–Oct. 1976), 3.

¹⁵⁰The Wizard, "Computer Phreak-Out," *TAP*, no. 51 (July 1978), 3.

¹⁵¹In fact, Rubin had rather famously transformed himself from a yippie into a "yuppie." See Pat Thomas, *Did it! From Yippie to Yuppie: Jerry Rubin, An American Revolutionary* (College Park, 2017). Authors within the high-tech countercultures of the 1980s and '90s were fascinated with the legacy of Hoffman, Rubin, and their compatriots. For example, see R. U. Sirius, "Yippie vs. Yuppie: A Yummie Commentary," *High Frontiers*, no. 2 (1985), <https://archi.vu.org/details/highfrontiers01rusi/page/n1/mode/2up> (accessed Apr. 25, 2025).

¹⁵²"Yippies are struggling to survive," *The Journal*, Sept. 20, 1973, 21.

¹⁵³Raskin, *For the Hell of It*, 254, 257.

drugs.”¹⁵⁴ Others offered more nuanced remembrances. In 1988, a reader letter in *Monitoring Times* recalled a “group called TAP in New York” and its “fun anarchy.”¹⁵⁵

But TAP’s Yippie origins were not without devotees. In 1984, the heir to YIPL/TAP’s publishing on phone phreak culture came in the form of *2600: The Hacker Quarterly*. Named for the 2600Hz tone phone phreaks used to access Bell’s long-distance telephone network, *2600* completed the synthesis of interests in telephony and computing that TAP failed to grasp. In 1989, *2600*’s founding editor, the hacker Eric Corley, who went by Emmanuel Goldstein, remembered TAP and eulogized Hoffman. YIPL/TAP, he wrote, was “the first publication to look at technology through hacker eyes.” Indeed, it was “doubtful” that *2600* would exist, the editorial continued, if previous magazines had not paved the way.

After Hoffman committed suicide in 1989, phreaks and hackers dedicated their many words to eulogizing Hoffman.¹⁵⁶ Corley was no exception. Though Hoffman never “hacked” into computer systems, Corley dubbed him “a hacker of the highest order.” Hoffman had earned this title because he “hacked authority” through the Yuppies and TAP, and, in the process, stood “up to the ultimate computer system known as Society.” Authorities of the 1960s and 1970s treated Hoffman then as they treated computer hackers in the 1980s: as a “pest” who never feared “point[ing] out the flaws” in society.¹⁵⁷ For all the nostalgia in their remembrances, by 1989, *2600*’s editors admitted that Hoffman’s influence was decidedly limited. “We’re sorry he never really seemed to reach the younger generation,” the editors wrote. Still, *2600* advised its readers to pause when “playing with a computer somewhere” and “say hello to Abbie. He’ll be right there.”¹⁵⁸

The idea of Hoffman and the phone phreaks of the 1970s became a founding mythology for the hackers, crackers, phreaks, and digital misfits who coalesced into a “computer underground” in the late 1980s.¹⁵⁹ The ensuing decades saw no fewer than four editions of a *Steal This Computer Book*, which introduced computer users to ideas about hackers and computer security, or *Steal This File Sharing Book*, wherein readers learned how to peruse the “warez” of pirated software from dominant (and perhaps monopolist) corporations like Microsoft.¹⁶⁰ The *Webster’s New World Hacker Dictionary* even styled Hoffman and YIPL as foundational for modern hacker culture.¹⁶¹ In the 1990s, debates about the nature of hacking even erupted between so-called “Bellheads” and “Netheads,” or hackers reared in the phreak’s day versus those who came of age on the electronic bulletin board systems of the 1980s and early 1990s.¹⁶² The phreak’s techniques, gimmicks, and Yippie-inspired penchant for the dramatic prank went on to shape the computerized countercultures of the 1980s, guiding what communities of hackers saw as socially and politically viable on the horizons of cyberspace.

More importantly, Hoffman continues to influence hackers. Take the hacktivists within the unruly global hacker group, Anonymous. Jeremy Hammond, for example, cut his hacktivist

¹⁵⁴E. Santos-Verde, “Tapped Out,” *Popular Communications* (Feb. 1985), 6.

¹⁵⁵Letter to the editor, “Phone Phreaking,” *Monitoring Times* 7, no. 2 (Mar. 1988), 92.

¹⁵⁶The zine W.O.R.M. [Write Once, Read Many], for example, dedicated its winter 1989 issue to Hoffman. See WORM [fax copy], box 85, John Perry Barlow Papers, Silicon Valley Archives, Stanford University.

¹⁵⁷Emmanuel Goldstein, “Remember . . .” *2600*, (Summer 1989).

¹⁵⁸Goldstein, “Remember . . .”.

¹⁵⁹See, for example, Tim Jordan and Paul Taylor, *Hacktivism and Cyberwars: Rebels with a Cause* (New York, 2004), 13. For an internalist account, see Gordon R. Meyer, *The Social Organization of the Computer Underground* (1989).

¹⁶⁰For the first edition, see Wally Wang, *Steal This Computer Book* (San Francisco, 1998); and Wally Wang, *Steal This File Sharing Book: What They Won’t Tell You About File Sharing* (San Francisco, 2005). On piracy, see Martin Paul Eve, *Ware: The Infrastructure and Aesthetics of Piracy* (Santa Barbara, 2021).

¹⁶¹Bernadette Schell and Clemens Martin, *Webster’s New World Hacker Dictionary* (Hoboken, 2005).

¹⁶²Steve G. Steinberg, “Netheads vs Bellheads,” *Wired*, Oct. 1, 1996, <https://www.wired.com/1996/10/atm-3/> (accessed Apr. 25, 2025). On electronic bulletin board systems, see Kevin Driscoll, *The Modem World: A Prehistory of Social Media* (New Haven, 2022).

teeth by founding and editing a website called *Hack This Zine*, an homage to Hoffman's work, and hacking conservative websites.¹⁶³ Like Hoffman, Hammond's writing blended both technical expertise and political commitment. From 2013 to 2020, Hammond was in prison for hacking a private intelligence firm, Stratfor, and leaking data to Anonymous. As one fellow hacker told *Rolling Stone*, Hammond was nothing less than a "modern-day Abbie Hoffman."¹⁶⁴ Such legacies of the political phreaking Hoffman represented, it seems, will continue to surprise.

In tracing the evolution of phone phreaking from a New Left-inflected act of resistance against the Bell System to a touchstone of libertarian hacker culture, we complicate the neat periodization of American political and technological change. Phreaking's early entanglement with antiwar activism, labor struggles, and critiques of monopoly capitalism underscores how technical practices are embedded within broader movements for social transformation. Its later adaptation into a politics of individual autonomy and technological resistance reveals the porous boundaries between the New Left, libertarianism, and hacker communities. By reading phreaking as both a material intervention in the infrastructure of American telephony and a symbolic gesture toward reimagining "the system," we see how users, activists, and tinkerers alike participated in shaping the meanings and possibilities of technology in modern America. This trajectory not only reframes the origins of hacker culture but also challenges us to see technological practice itself as an enduring—and contested—form of political action.

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¹⁶³Coleman, *Hacker, Hoaxer, Whistleblower, Spy*, 280.

¹⁶⁴Janet Reitman, "The Rise and Fall of Jeremy Hammond: Enemy of the State," *The Rolling Stone*, Dec. 7, 2012, <https://www.rollingstone.com/culture/culture-news/the-rise-and-fall-of-jeremy-hammond-enemy-of-the-state-183599/> (accessed Apr. 25, 2025).